Grade 8 practice paper 1

Time allowed: 3 hours · 100 marks · pass 66, merit 80, distinction 90

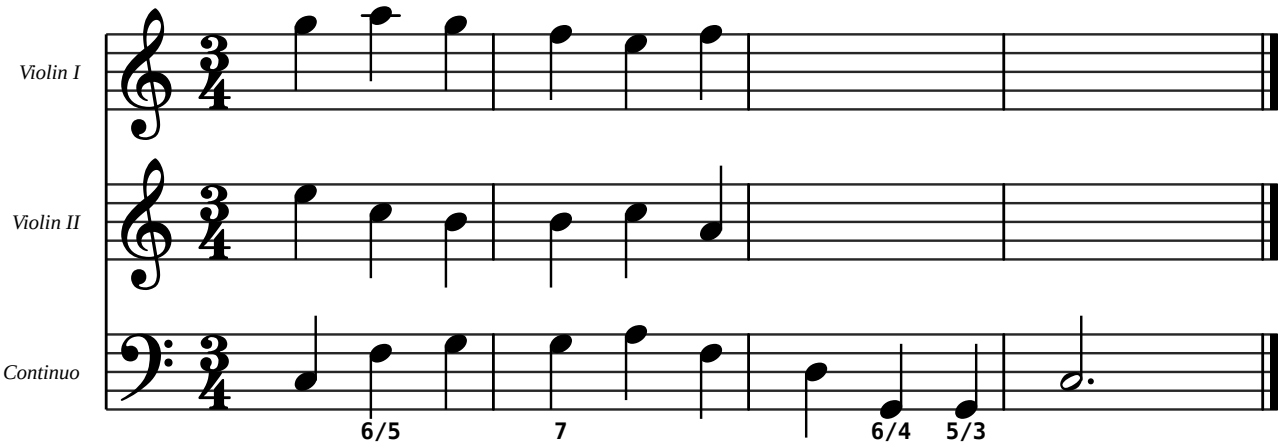
Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 100

Our own paper in the style of the ABRSM Grade 8 exam, not an ABRSM paper. Answer every question. Suggested timing: questions 1 and 2, 25 minutes each; question 3, 35 minutes; questions 4 and 5, 35 minutes each; 25 minutes to check.

Question 1: A trio sonata (15 marks)

15 marks

1. Continue the two violin parts of this trio sonata (C major) to the end, following the figured bass. Keep the parts independent and write a cadence at the end.
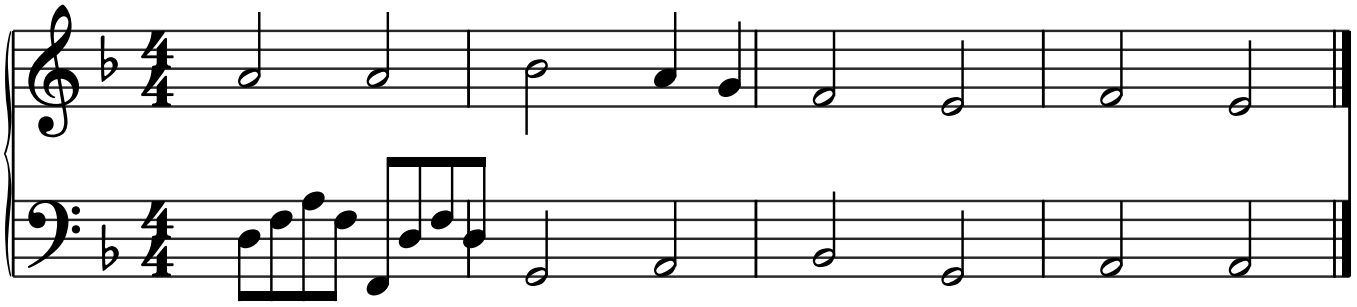


Copy onto manuscript paper, or write straight onto the staves above.

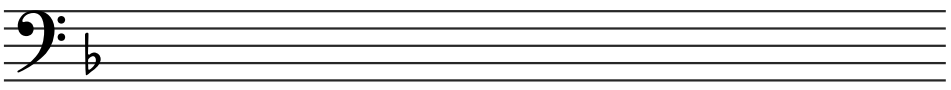
Question 2: Completing a keyboard piece (15 marks)

15 marks

2. Complete this keyboard outline (D minor). Bar 1 is complete; in the other bars the melody and bass are given. Continue the left-hand broken chord to the end, fitting each chord.



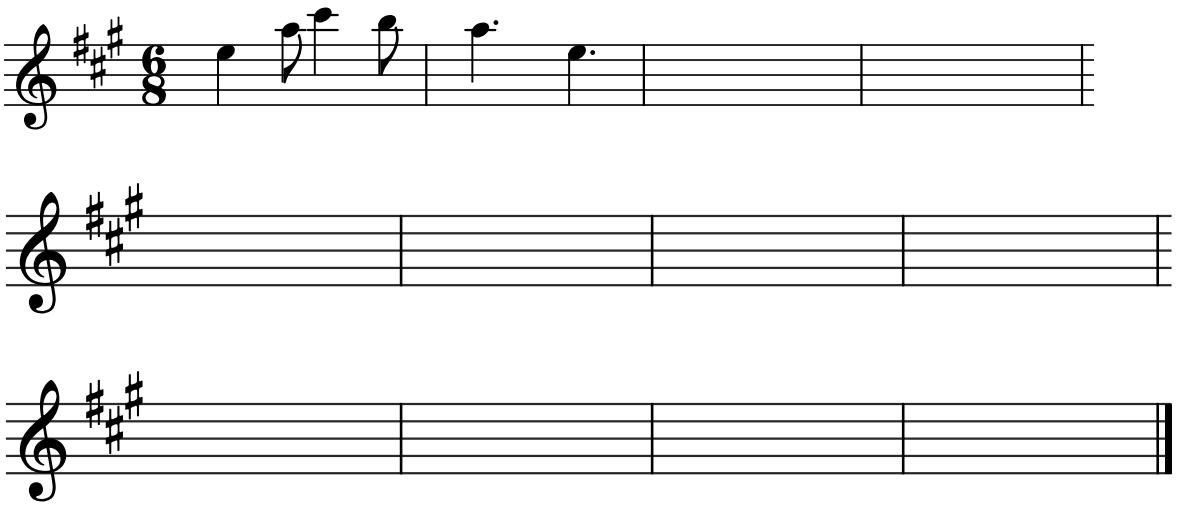
Pattern: broken chord. Write the left hand in the empty bars.



Question 3: Composition (20 marks)

20 marks

3. Composition: continue this opening for oboe (A major) to make a melody of at least 12 bars. Modulate to a related key and come back, and add performance directions.
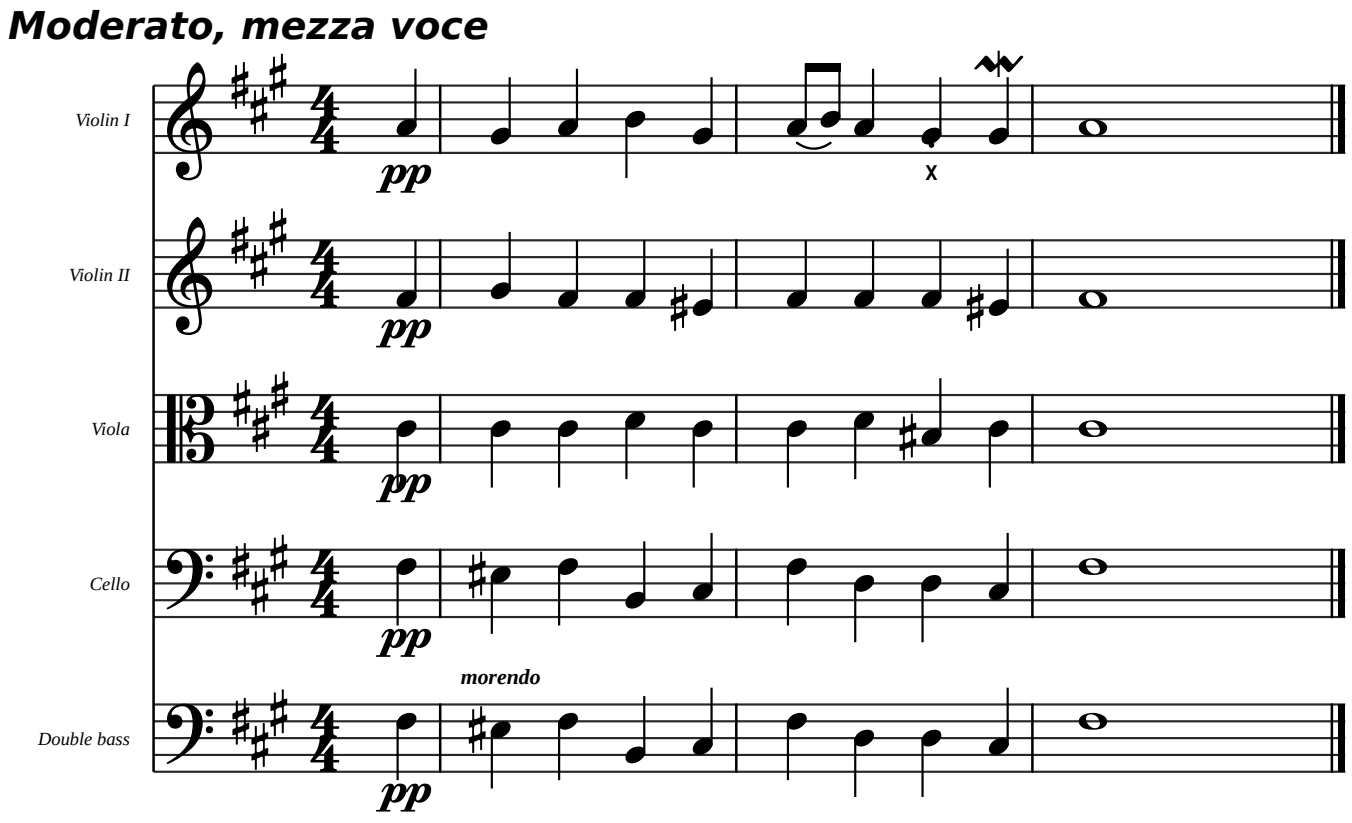


Oboe range: B♭3 to about F6. Add tempo, dynamics, phrasing and articulation.

Question 4: A chamber score (25 marks)

3 marks

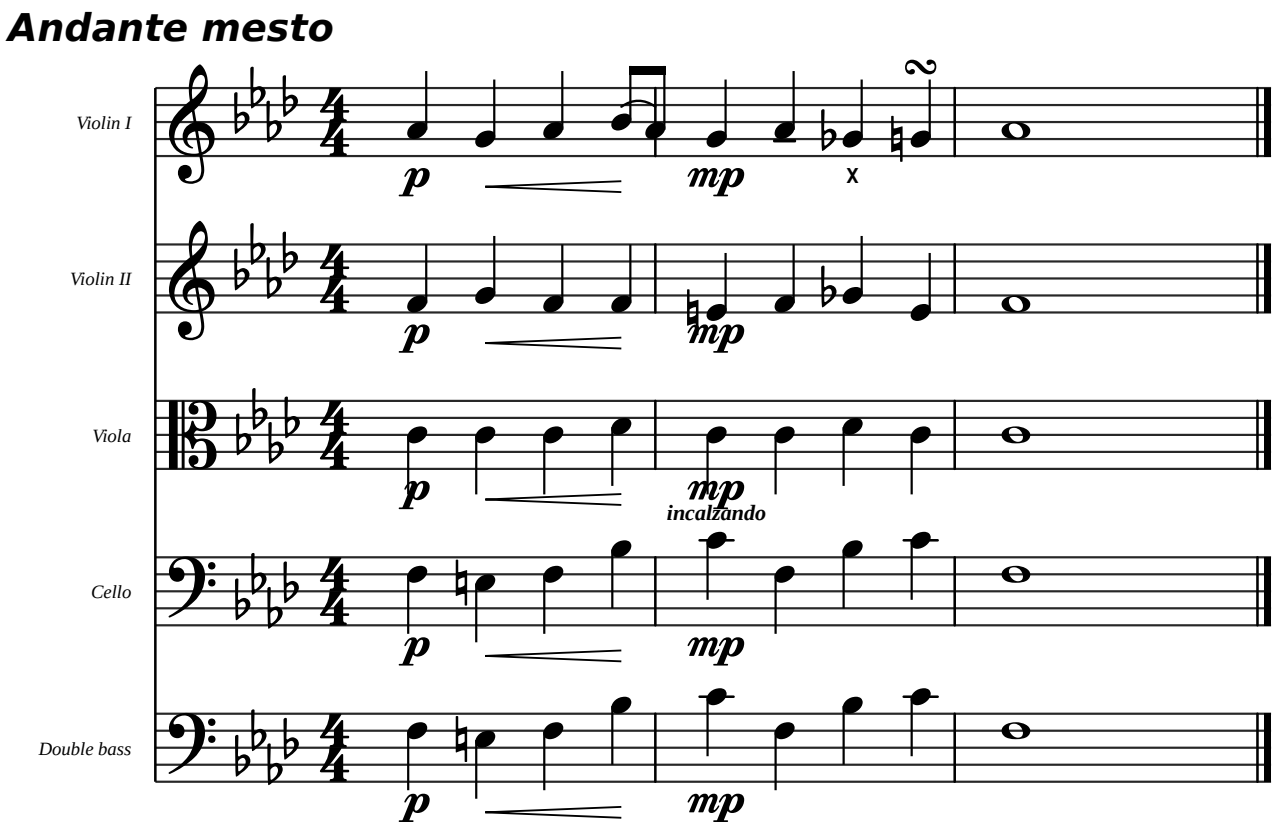
4. This piano quintet sounds in F♯ minor. Name the chord at X.



A. Fr6 B. VIb C. Vb D. IV

3 marks

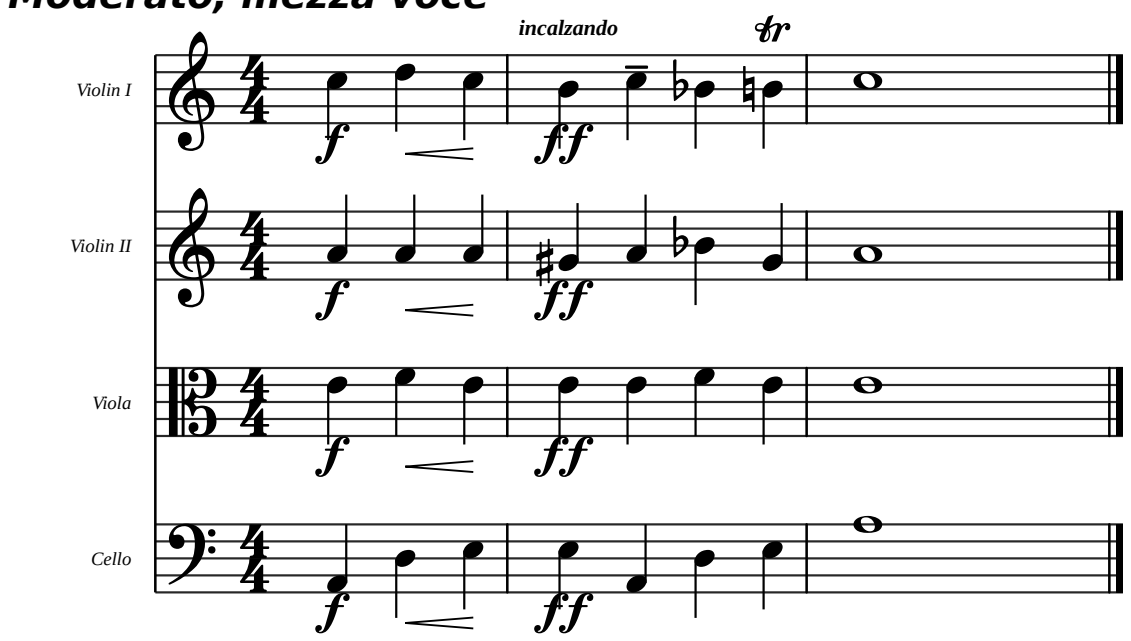
5. This piano quintet sounds in F minor. Name the chord at X.



A. VIb B. V/V C. Ger6 D. N6

3 marks

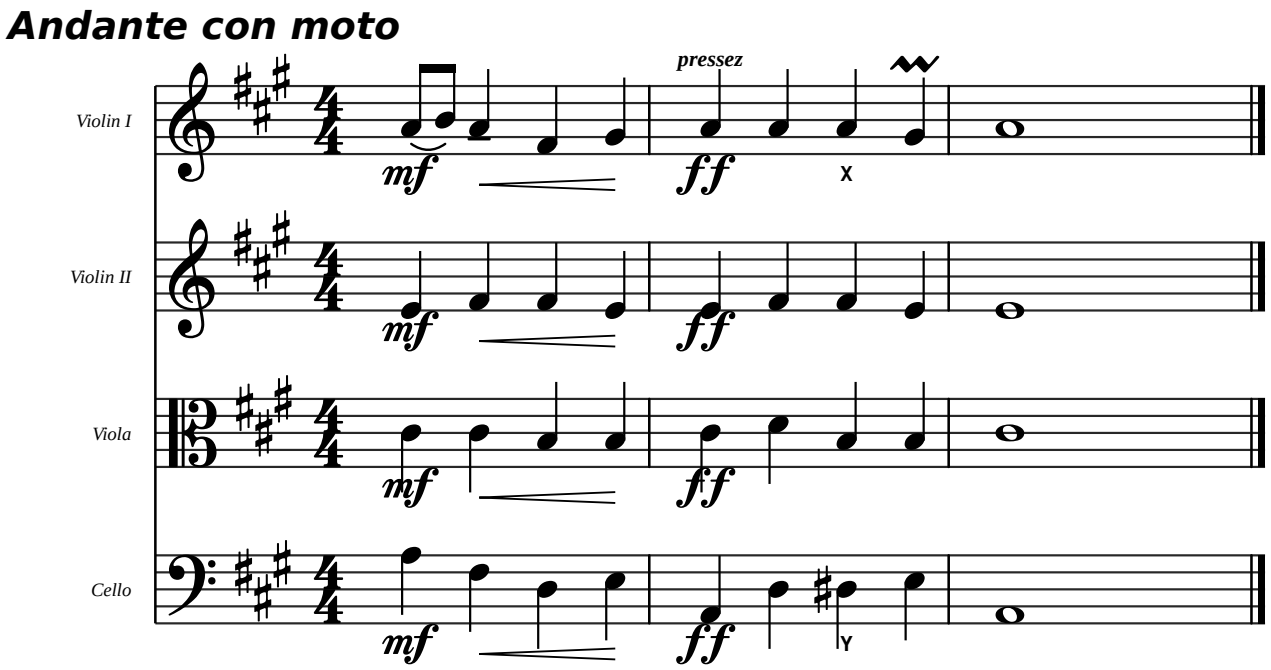
6. Which ornament is written over the violin I's note in bar 1? (bar 1 is the first complete bar)



A. a turn B. an upper mordent C. a lower mordent D. a trill

3 marks

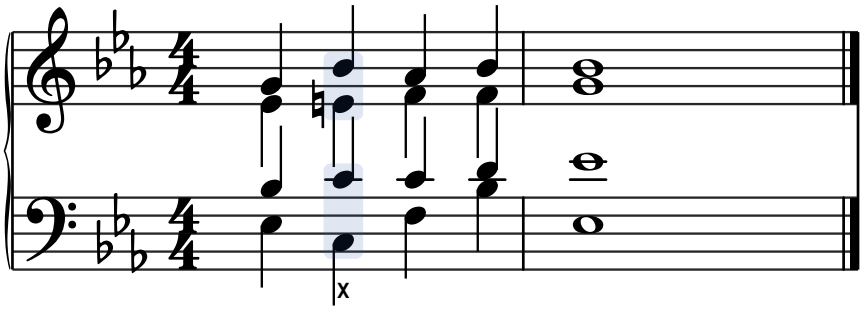
7. Name the interval between the SOUNDING notes at X (violin I) and Y (cello).



A. compound minor 5th B. compound major 5th C. compound diminished 5th D. diminished 5th

3 marks

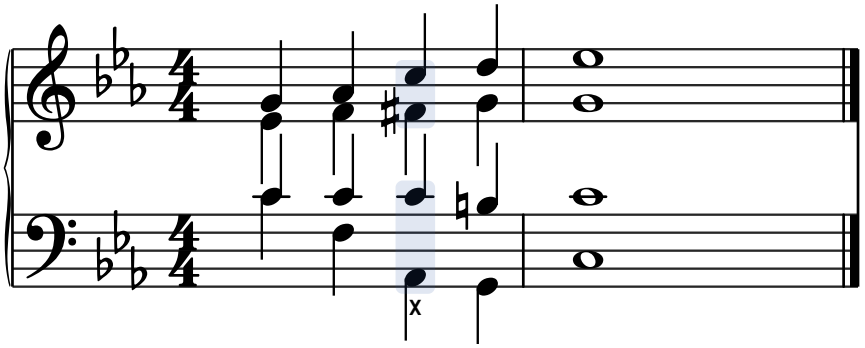
8. This passage is in E♭ major. Name the chord marked X.



A. V7/V B. II7d C. I7d D. V7/II

3 marks

9. This passage is in C minor. Name the chord marked X.



A. VI7 B. It6 C. II7c D. IIb

3 marks
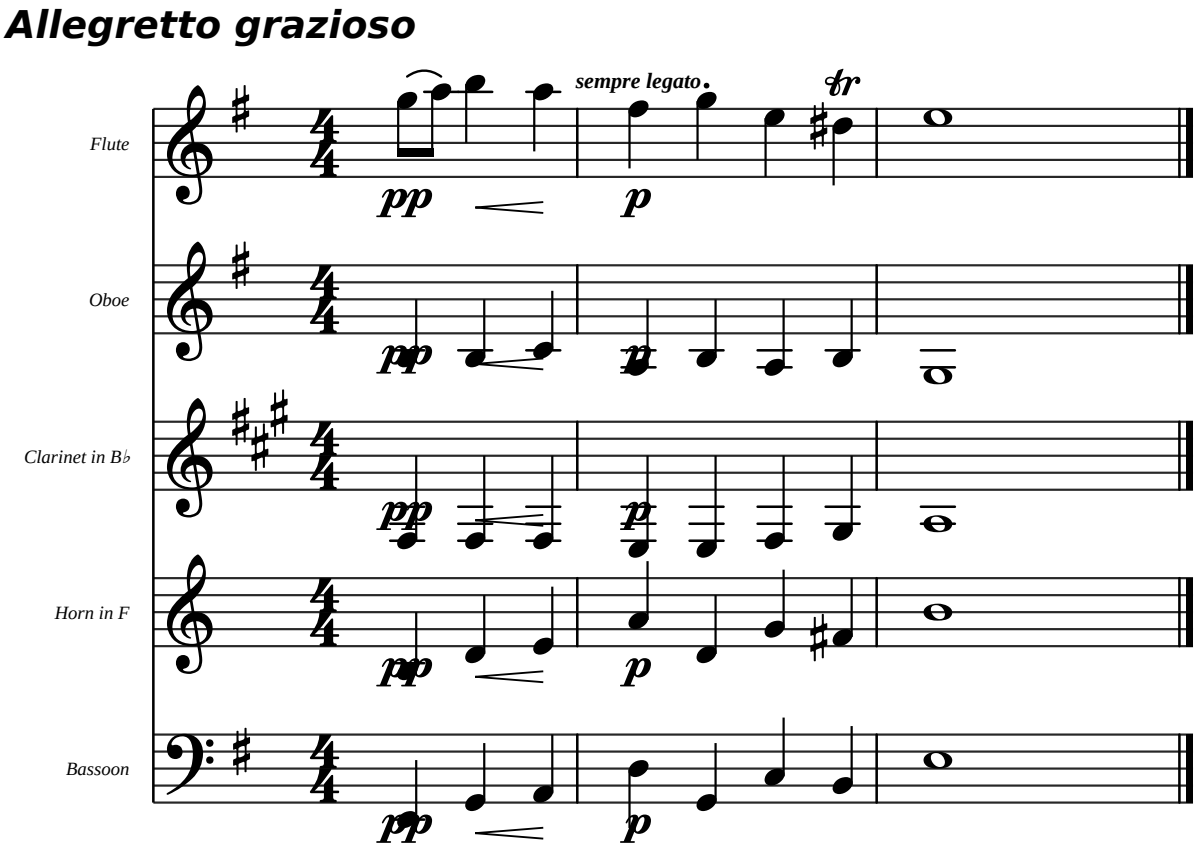
10. What does this mean?

stringendo

A. marked, accented (German) B. mysteriously C. getting livelier (French) D. pressing on, getting faster

4 marks

11. This wind quintet begins in E minor. In which key is the cadence that ends in bar 1? (Bar 1 is the first complete bar.)
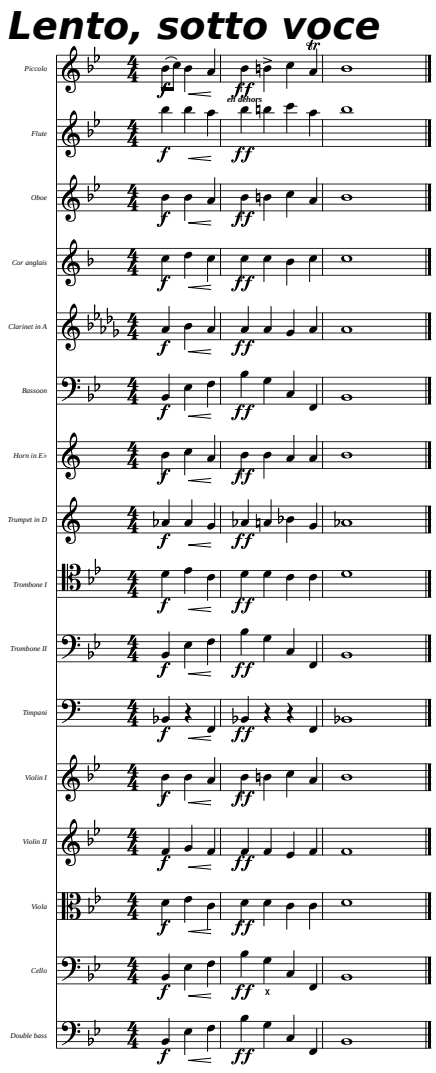


A. G major B. B minor C. A minor D. F♯ minor

Question 5: An orchestral score (25 marks)

3 marks
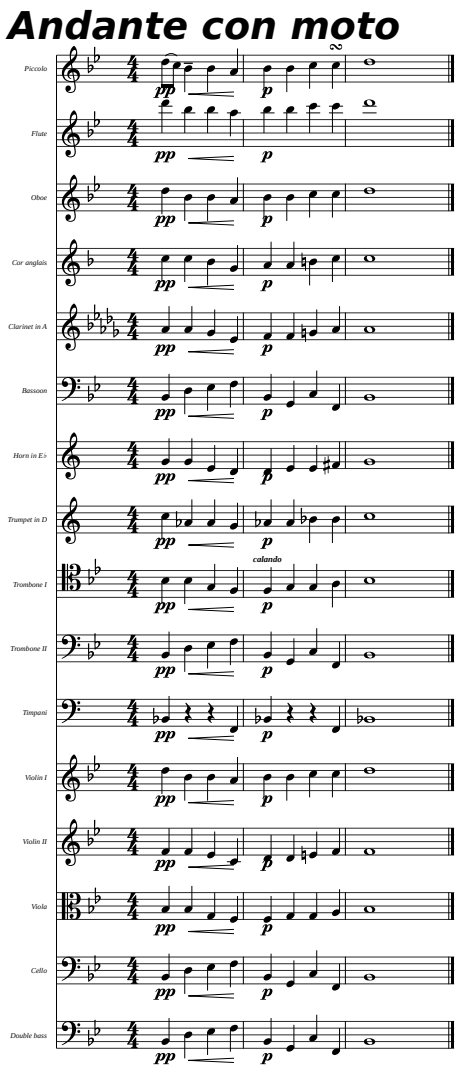
12. This extract sounds in B♭ major. Name the chord at X.



A. Ic B. V7/II C. I7 D. Vb

3 marks
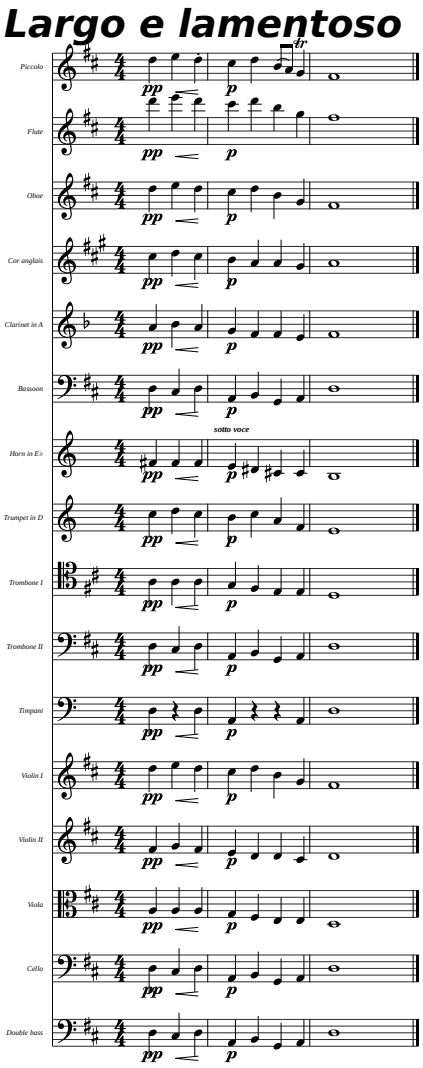
13. What does the hairpin sign under the staves in the first bars tell the players to do?



A. get gradually quieter B. get gradually louder C. play smoothly D. get gradually faster

3 marks
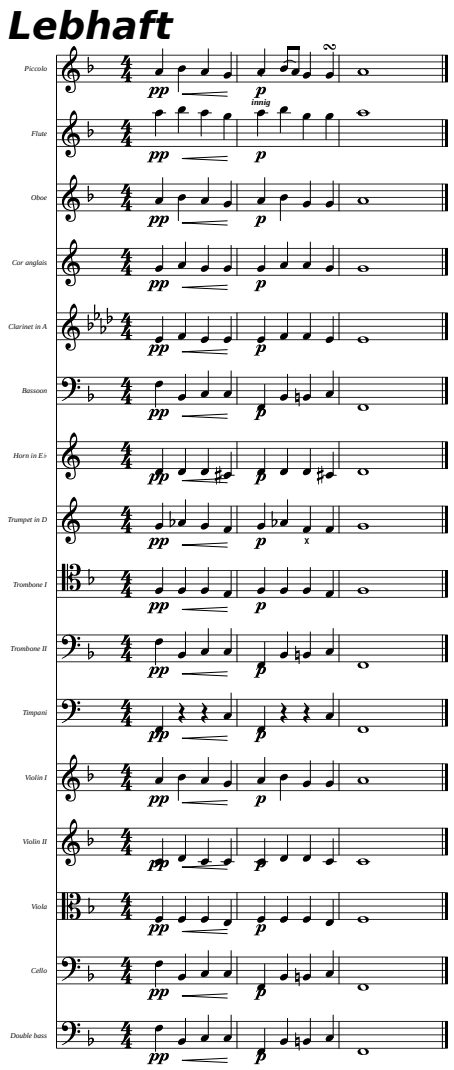
14. This extract sounds in D major. Name the chord at X.



A. V7/II B. I C. IV7d D. IV7c

3 marks

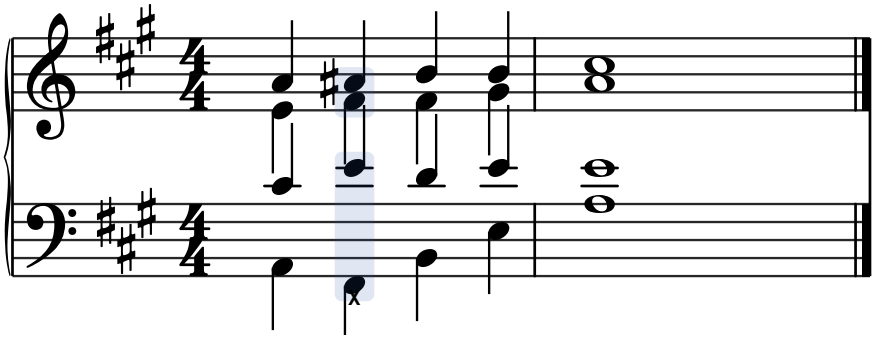
15. The trumpet in D plays the written note at X. Which note actually sounds?



A. B♭ B. E C. G D. A

3 marks

16. This passage is in A major. Name the chord marked X.



A. V7/II B. VII7c C. Ib D. V7/V

3 marks

17. What does this mean?

mezza voce

A. at half voice, restrained B. getting livelier (French) C. let it vibrate (don't damp the sound) D. very (German)

3 marks
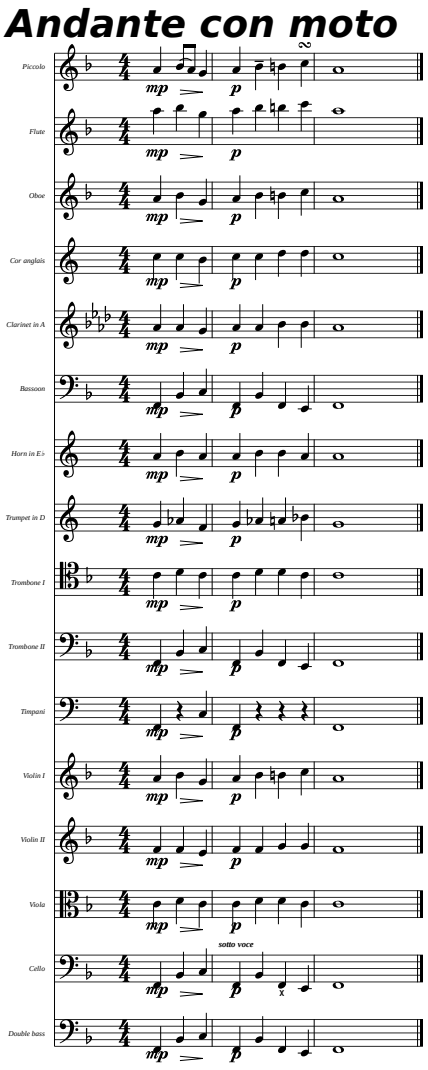
18. What does this mean?

lontano

A. bow over the fingerboard (French) B. marked, accented (German) C. distant D. bow near the bridge

4 marks

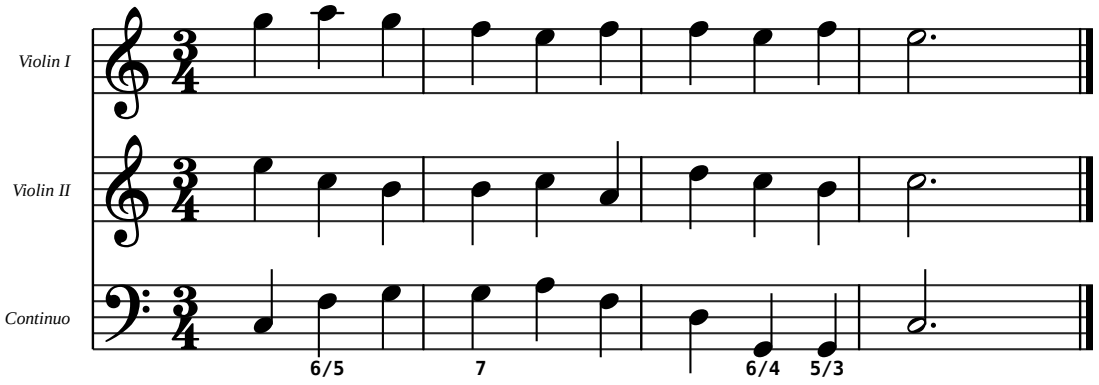
19. This extract sounds in F major. Name the chord at X.



A. V7b/V B. V7d/V C. I7d D. I7b

MARKING KEY (FOR MUM)
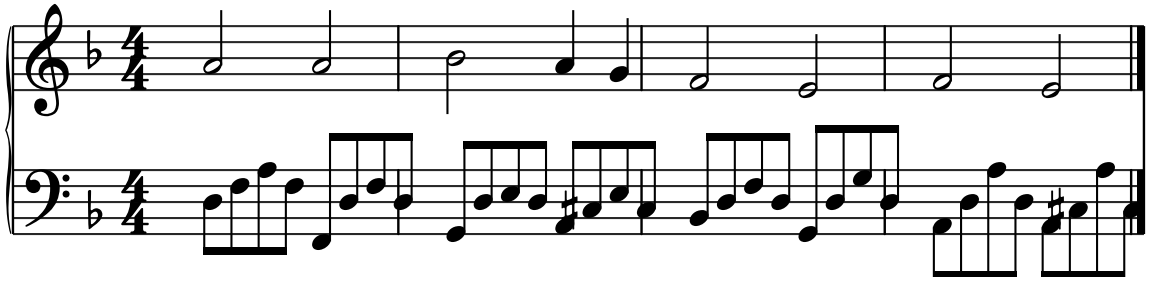
1. Q1 · 15m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.



   1. Every chord follows the figures, with the 3rd present
   2. No consecutive 5ths or octaves between any two parts (including the bass)
   3. The two violins are independent: contrary or oblique motion, some imitation or sequence
   4. Leading notes rise, 7ths fall, suspensions are prepared and resolve down
   5. The violins stay mostly within an octave of each other (they may cross)
   6. Some quaver movement for life; a clear cadence at the end

   Marking: start from 15. Take off 2 for each wrong chord, missing 3rd or consecutive; 1 for a weak part (no movement, too far apart). Other good answers earn full marks.

2. Q2 · 15m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.
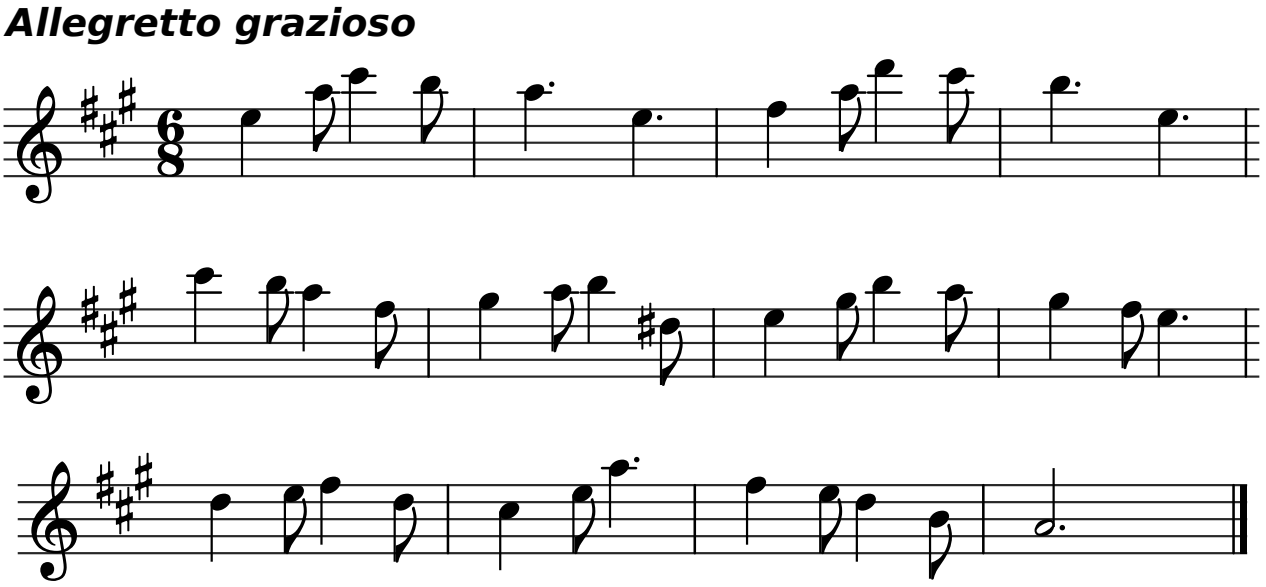


   Chords: I – Ib – II7b – V – VI – II7b – Ic – V

   1. The pattern from bar 1 is kept exactly in shape and rhythm
   2. Every bar fits the harmony implied by the melody and bass
   3. Chromatic notes (secondary dominants, augmented 6ths) are spelled correctly
   4. No consecutive octaves or 5ths between the melody and the bass
   5. The cadence is clear, ending on a full tonic chord
   6. The texture suits the piano: comfortable for the hands

   Marking: start from 15. Take off 1–2 for each bar with a wrong chord or a broken pattern, and 2 for each consecutive.

3. Q3 · 20m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.



   1. Bars 1–4: the lilting opening, a sequence a step higher, and a pause on E over the dominant.
   2. Bars 5–8: D♯ takes the music to E major (the dominant), cadencing in bar 8.
   3. Bars 9–12: D♮ returns to A major; the melody winds down to the tonic.

   Checklist:

   1. At least 12 bars, every bar the right length
   2. Clear phrases (often 4 + 4 + 4) with cadences at the ends
   3. The opening idea comes back, varied or developed (sequence, inversion, new rhythm)
   4. A modulation to a related key with the right accidental, then a clear return
   5. One high point, a good balance of steps and leaps, a strong ending on the tonic
   6. Written for the instrument: range, breathing or bowing, idiomatic figures
   7. Tempo, dynamics with changes, phrasing and articulation
4. Q4 · 3m **A: Fr6**. Sounding notes at X: D, B♯, F♯, G♯: D–F♯–G♯–B♯, so Fr6, a French augmented 6th.
5. Q4 · 3m **D: N6**. Sounding notes at X: B♭, D♭, G♭, G♭: G♭–B♭–D♭, so N6.
6. Q4 · 3m **D: a trill**. The sign is a trill.
7. Q4 · 3m **C: compound diminished 5th**. The violin I sounds A4; the cello sounds D♯3. That's 12 letter names apart: a compound diminished 5th.
8. Q4 · 3m **D: V7/II**. X is C–E–G–B♭: V7/II, a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II). It is V7 of the key of II, so its leading note (E) rises to the root of II.
9. Q4 · 3m **B: It6**. X is A♭–C–F♯: It6, an Italian augmented 6th. Its augmented 6th (between the bass and the ♯4) opens out to the octave on the dominant.
10. Q4 · 3m **D: pressing on, getting faster**. stringendo means "pressing on, getting faster".
11. Q4 · 4m **A: G major**. The music modulates to G major, the relative major: the leading note's sharp disappears, and the cadence is V–I in G major.
12. Q5 · 3m **B: V7/II**. Read the strings (they don't transpose): G, D, F, B: G–B–D–F, so V7/II, a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II).
13. Q5 · 3m **B: get gradually louder**. The hairpin opens out for a crescendo and closes for a diminuendo: here it opens: crescendo, from pp to p.
14. Q5 · 3m **B: I**. Read the strings (they don't transpose): D, A, F♯, D: D–F♯–A, so I.
15. Q5 · 3m **C: G**. The trumpet in D sounds a major 2nd higher than written: written F sounds as G.

16. Q5 · 3m **A: V7/II**. X is F♯–A♯–C♯–E: V7/II, a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II). It is V7 of the key of II, so its leading note (A♯) rises to the root of II.
17. Q5 · 3m **A: at half voice, restrained**. mezza voce means "at half voice, restrained".
18. Q5 · 3m **C: distant**. lontano means "distant".
19. Q5 · 4m **B: V7d/V**. Read the strings (they don't transpose): F, D, G, B: G–B–D–F, so V7d/V, a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of V).

Grade 8 practice paper 2

Time allowed: 3 hours · 100 marks · pass 66, merit 80, distinction 90

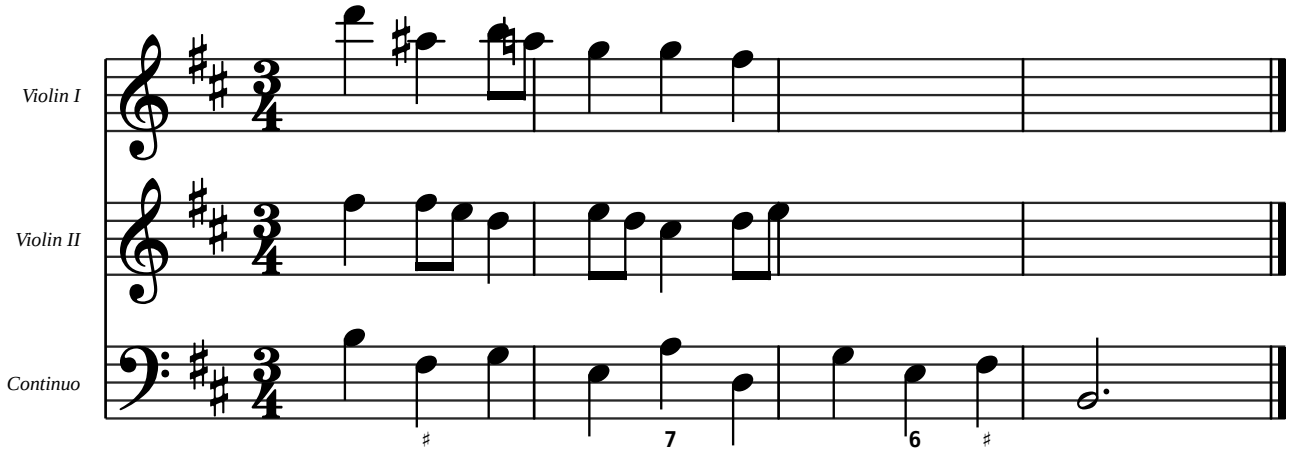
Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 100

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Question 1: A trio sonata (15 marks)

15 marks

1. Continue the two violin parts of this trio sonata (B minor) to the end, following the figured bass. It modulates to D major and back. Keep the parts independent and write a cadence at the end.
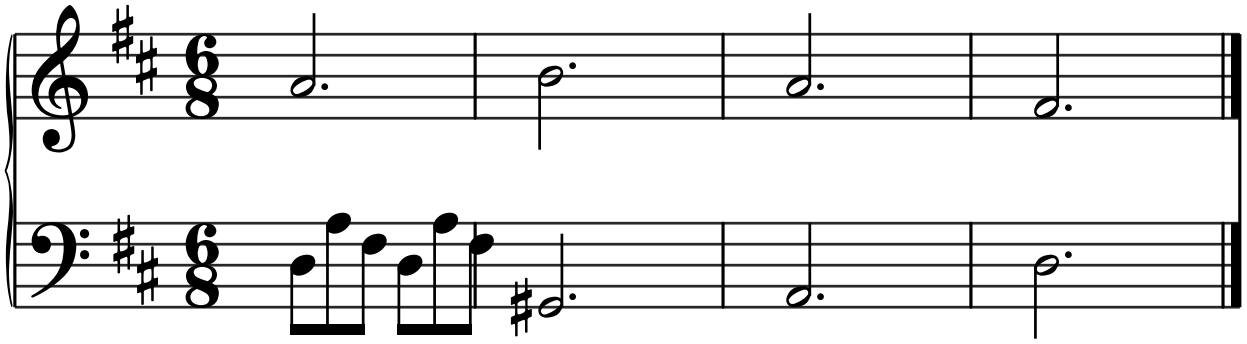


Copy onto manuscript paper, or write straight onto the staves above.

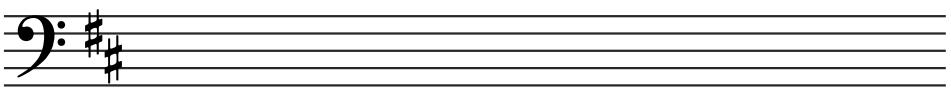
Question 2: Completing a keyboard piece (15 marks)

15 marks

2. Complete this keyboard outline (D major). Bar 1 is complete; in the other bars the melody and bass are given. Continue the left-hand rocking quavers to the end, fitting each chord.



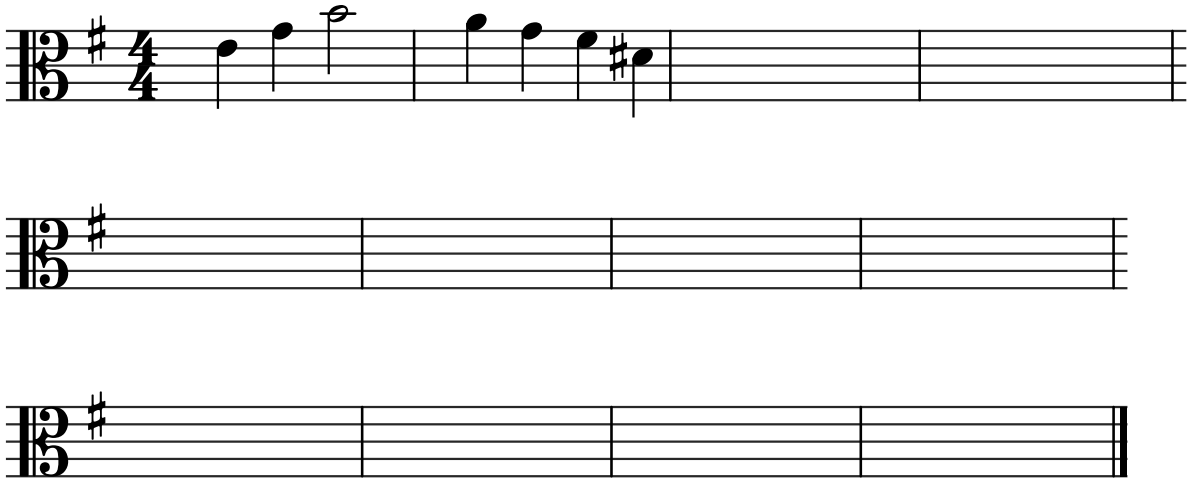
Pattern: rocking quavers. Write the left hand in the empty bars.



Question 3: Composition (20 marks)

20 marks

3. Composition: continue this opening for viola (E minor) to make a melody of at least 12 bars. Modulate to a related key and come back, and add performance directions.
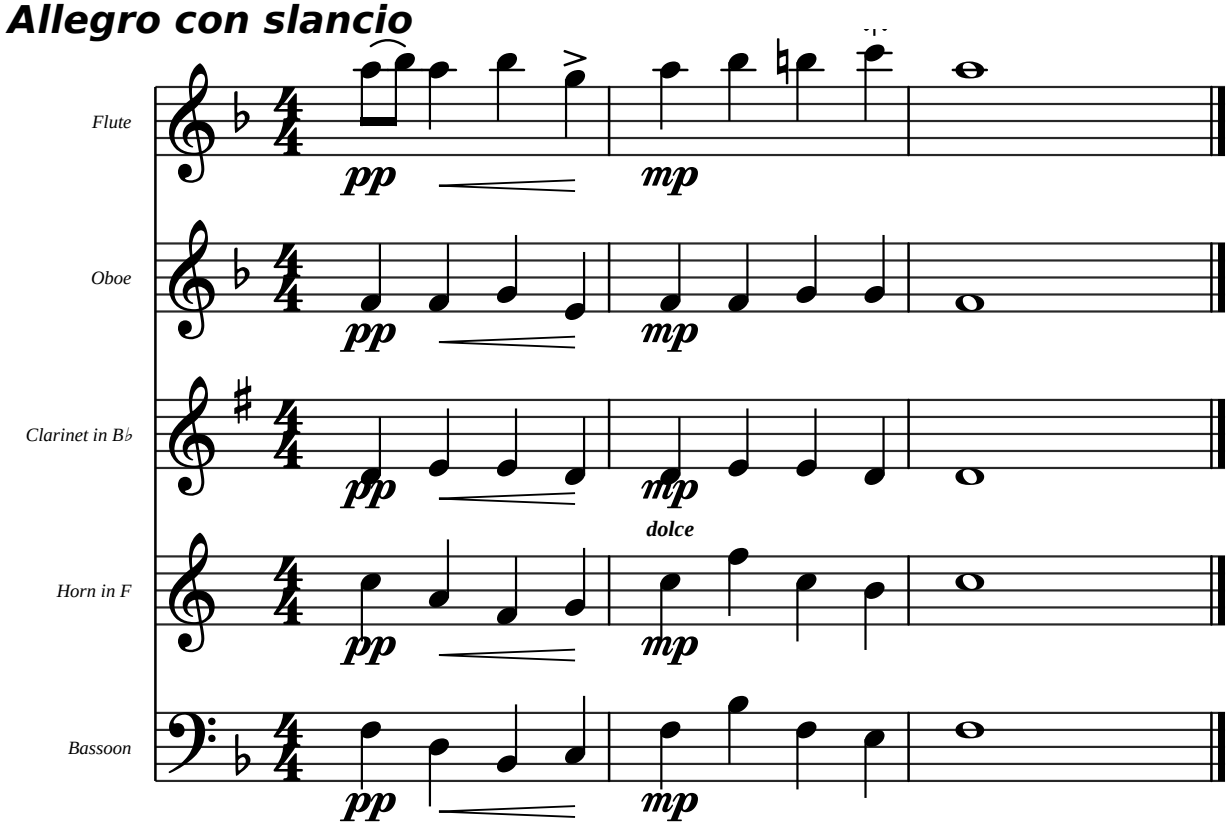


Viola range: C3 upwards (comfortably up to about E5). Add tempo, dynamics, phrasing and articulation.

Question 4: A chamber score (25 marks)

3 marks

4. What does the mark on the flute's note in bar 1 tell the player?



A. tenuto: hold it for its full length, slightly stressed
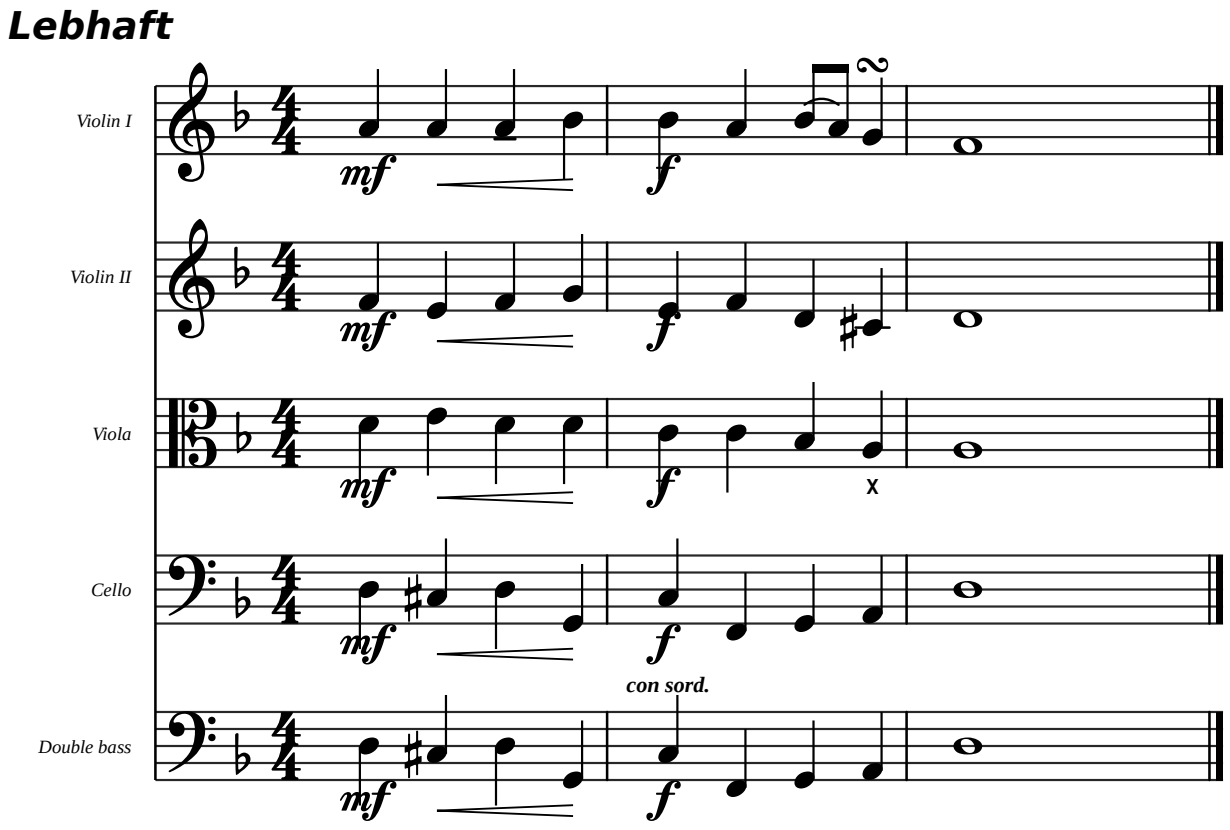
B. pause on the note

C. staccato: short and detached

D. an accent: play it with extra emphasis

3 marks
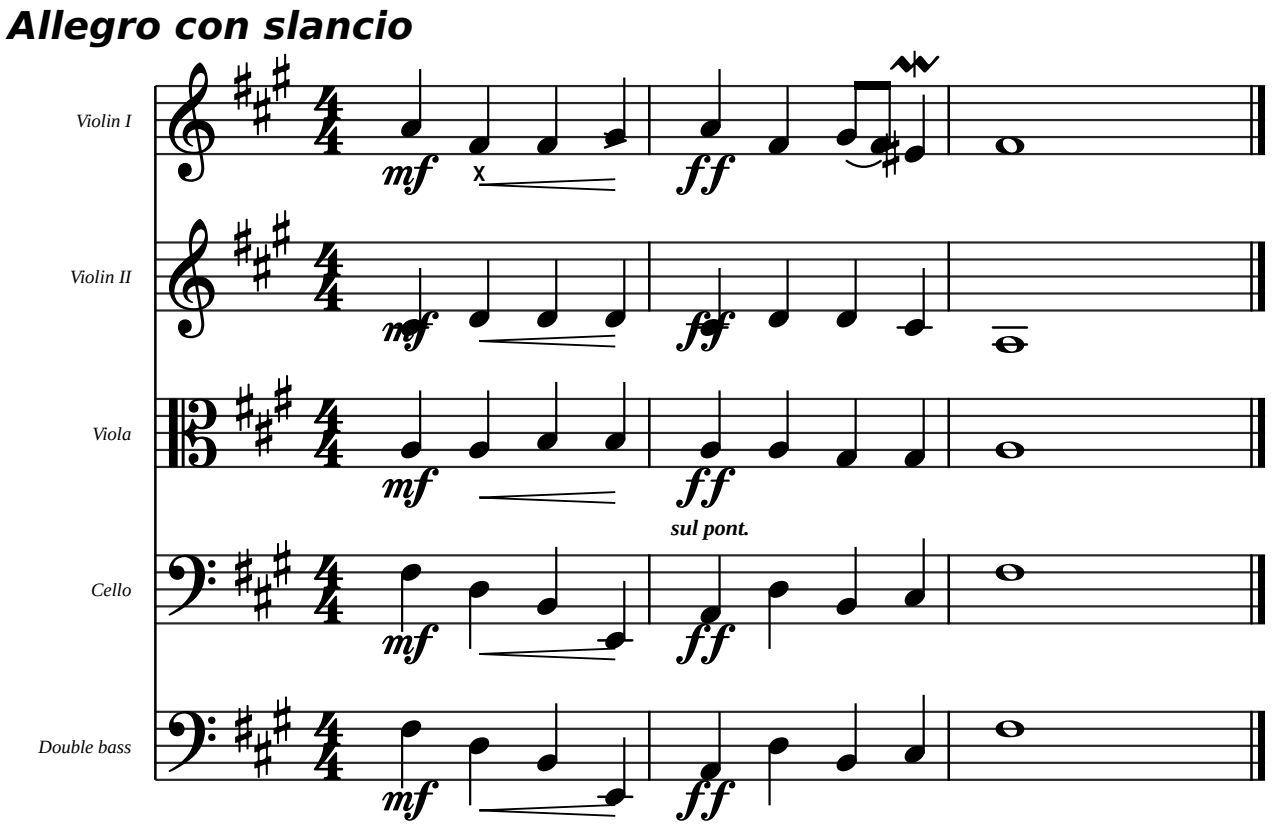
5. Name the viola's note at X, with its octave (middle C is C4).



A. A2 B. G3 C. B♭3 D. A3

3 marks
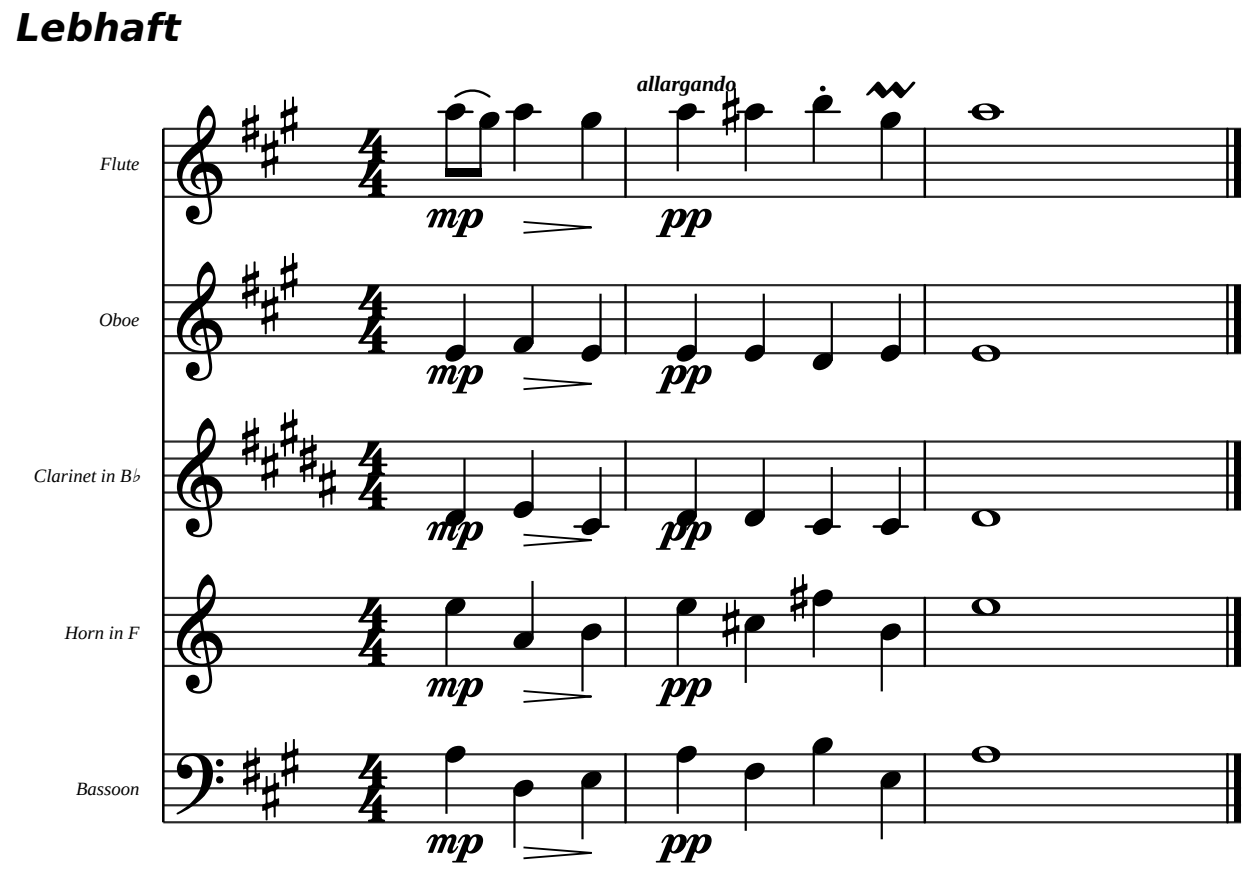
6. This piano quintet is in F♯ minor. What kind of chord is heard at X?



A. a triad B. a dominant 7th C. a French augmented 6th D. a German augmented 6th

3 marks
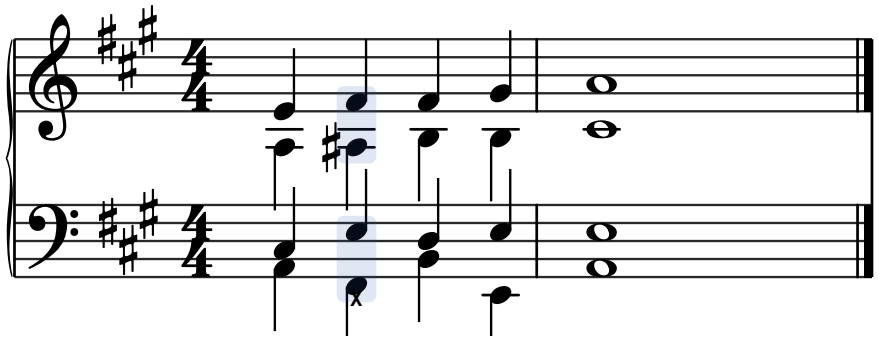
7. What does the tempo marking "Lebhaft" mean?



A. lively (German) B. slow, in an undertone C. fairly quick and graceful D. slow, heartfelt (German)

3 marks

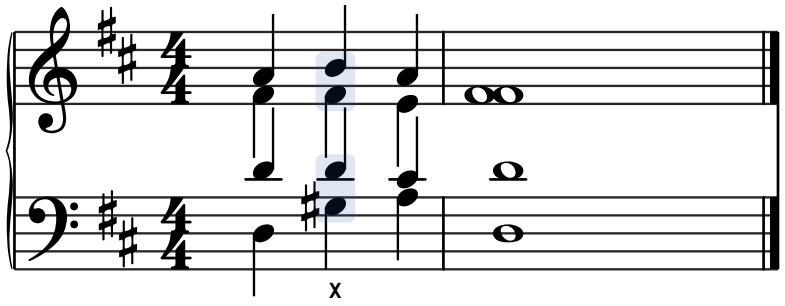
8. This passage is in A major. What kind of chord is X?



A. a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II) B. a French augmented 6th C. a German augmented 6th D. a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of V)

3 marks

9. This passage is in D major. Name the chord marked X.



A. V7d B. IIb C. I7 D. VII7/V
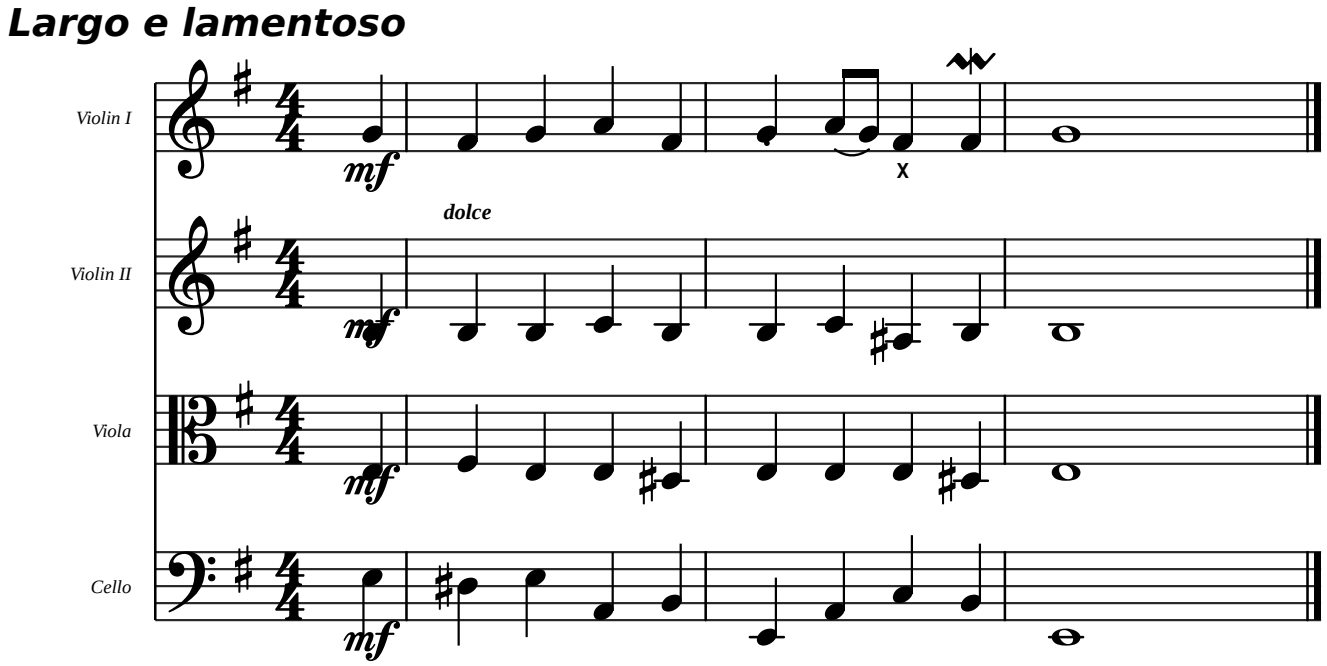
3 marks

10. Which term means "at the same speed (the beat stays the same)"?

A. l'istesso tempo B. sur la touche C. en dehors D. a 2

4 marks

11. This string quartet sounds in E minor. Name the chord at X.
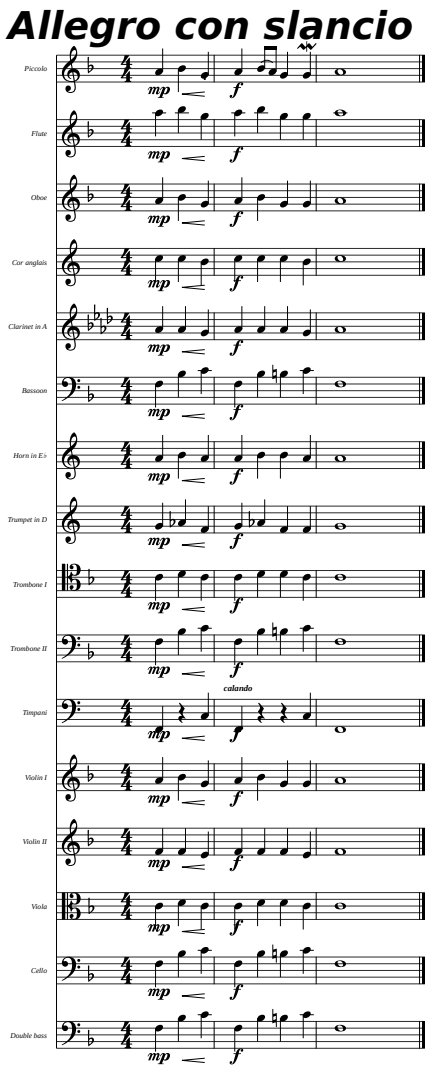


A. IIb B. V/IV C. Fr6 D. Vb

Question 5: An orchestral score (25 marks)

3 marks
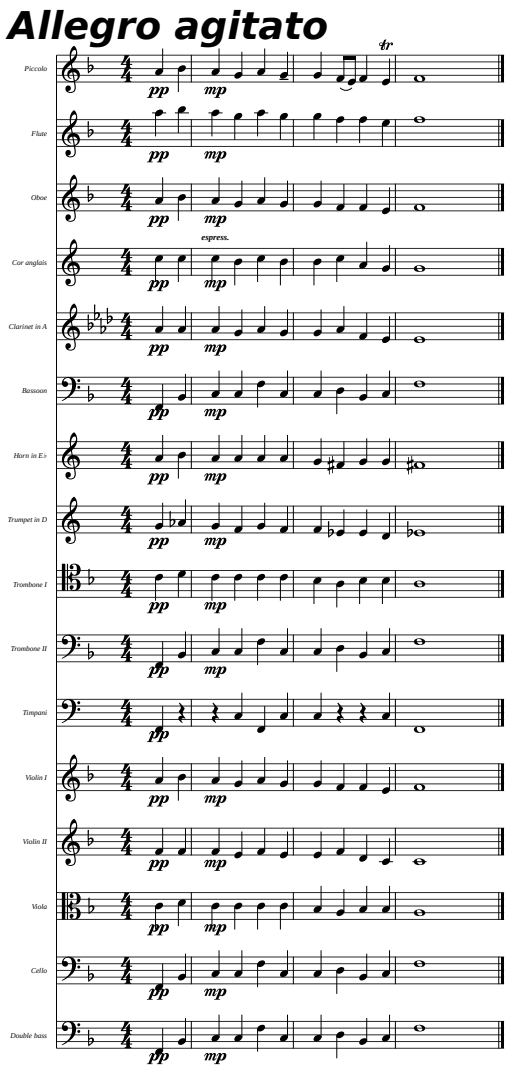
12. What does "calando" over the timpani in bar 1 mean? (bar 1 is the first complete bar)



A. getting softer and slower B. broadening, getting slower and fuller C. dying away D. sweetly

3 marks

13. The piccolo is written an octave lower than the flute here. How do the two sound?



A. the piccolo sounds an octave lower than the flute
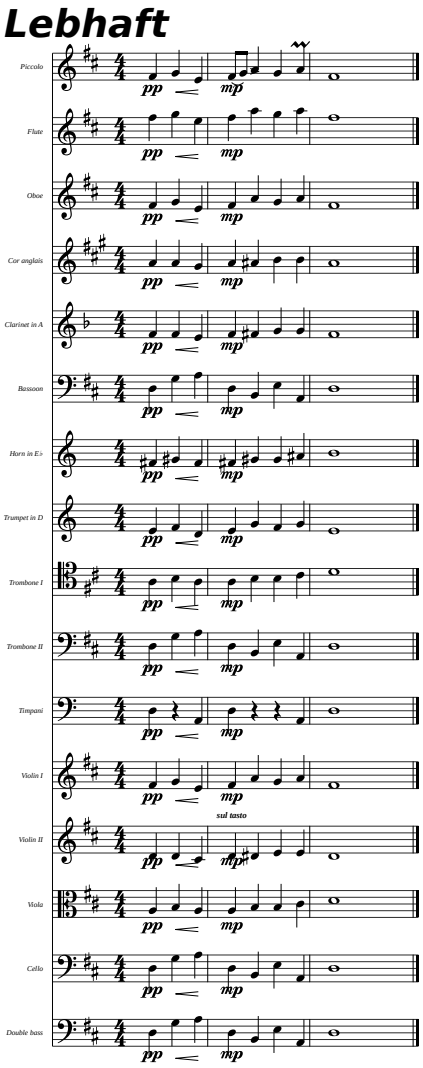
B. the flute sounds an octave lower than written

C. in unison: the piccolo sounds an octave higher than written

D. the piccolo sounds two octaves higher than the flute

3 marks

14. The piccolo is written an octave lower than the flute here. How do the two sound?



A. the piccolo sounds an octave lower than the flute
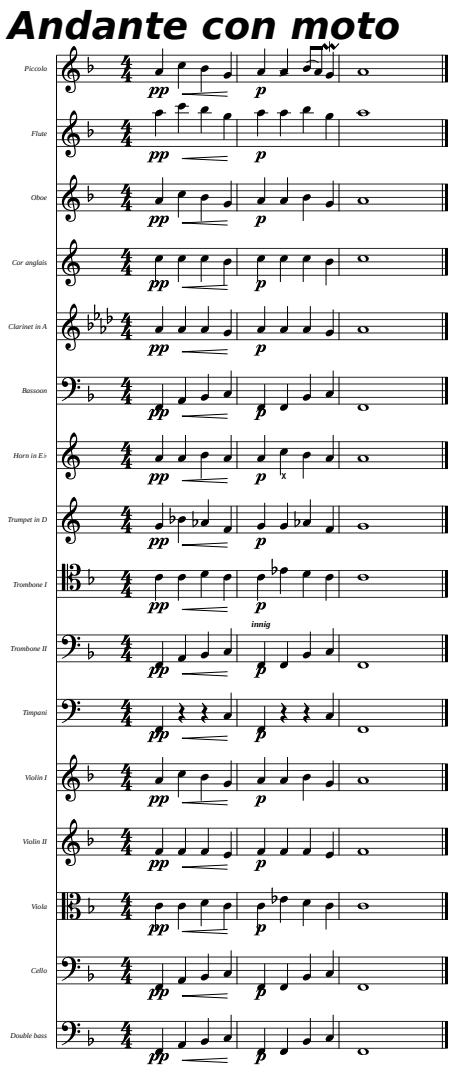
B. the piccolo sounds two octaves higher than the flute

C. in unison: the piccolo sounds an octave higher than written

D. the flute sounds an octave lower than written

3 marks

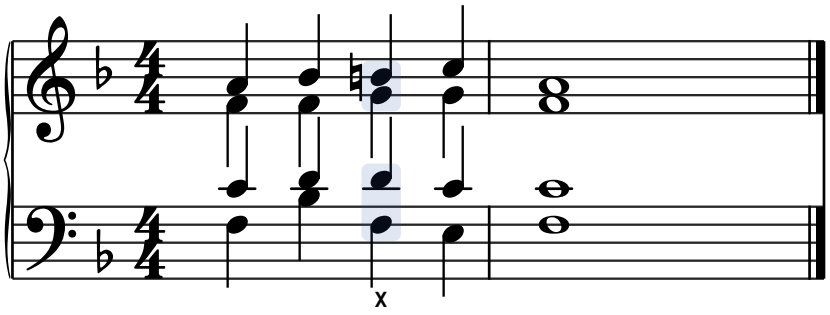
15. The horn in E♭ plays the written note at X. Which note actually sounds?



A. F B. C C. E♭ D. G

3 marks

16. This passage is in F major. What kind of chord is X?



A. a diminished 7th B. a German augmented 6th C. a French augmented 6th D. a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of V)

3 marks

17. What does this mean?

piangevole

A. the main part: bring it out (German)
B. lively (German)
C. brought out, prominent (French)
D. plaintive, tearful

3 marks
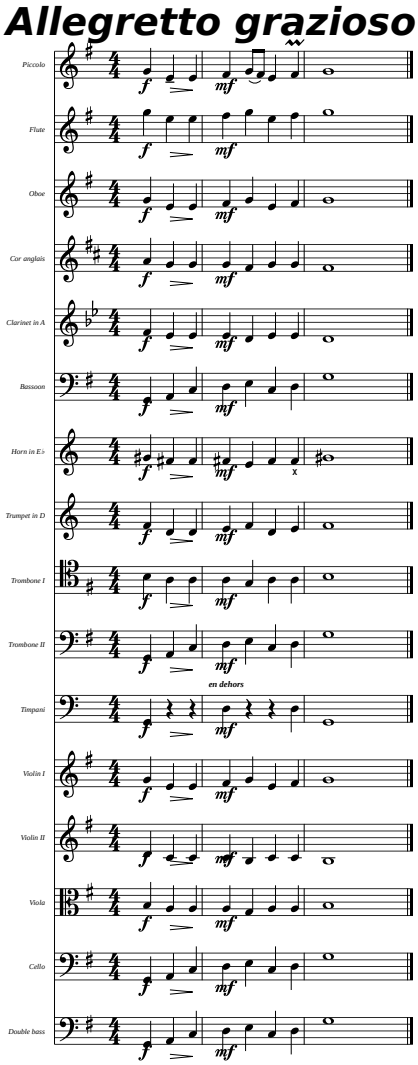
18. What does this mean?

smorzando (smorz.)

A. plaintive, tearful
B. dying away
C. flutter-tonguing (German)
D. sustained

4 marks

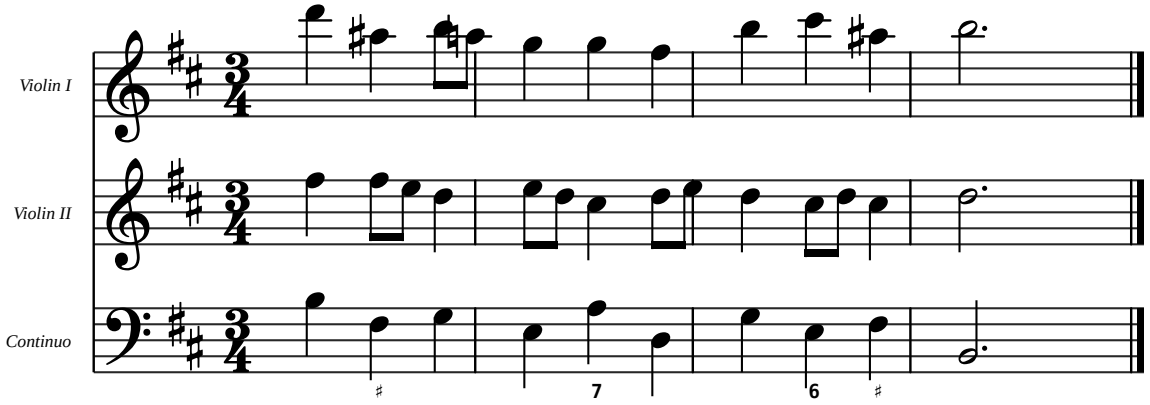
19. The horn in E♭ plays the written note at X. Which note actually sounds?



A. A
B. F♯
C. B
D. C

MARKING KEY (FOR MUM)

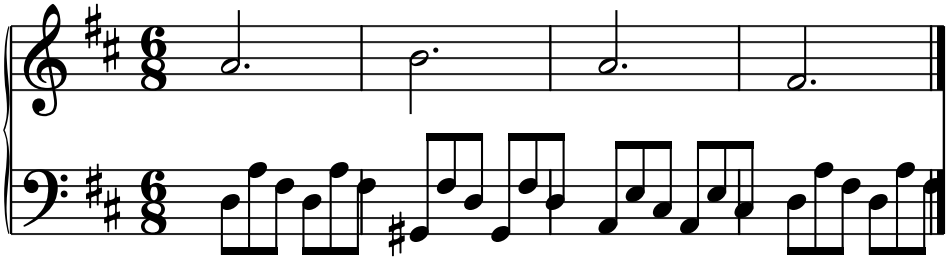
1. Q1 · 15m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.



   1. Every chord follows the figures, with the 3rd present
   2. No consecutive 5ths or octaves between any two parts (including the bass)
   3. The two violins are independent: contrary or oblique motion, some imitation or sequence
   4. Leading notes rise, 7ths fall, suspensions are prepared and resolve down
   5. The violins stay mostly within an octave of each other (they may cross)
   6. Some quaver movement for life; a clear cadence at the end

   Marking: start from 15. Take off 2 for each wrong chord, missing 3rd or consecutive; 1 for a weak part (no movement, too far apart). Other good answers earn full marks.

2. Q2 · 15m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.
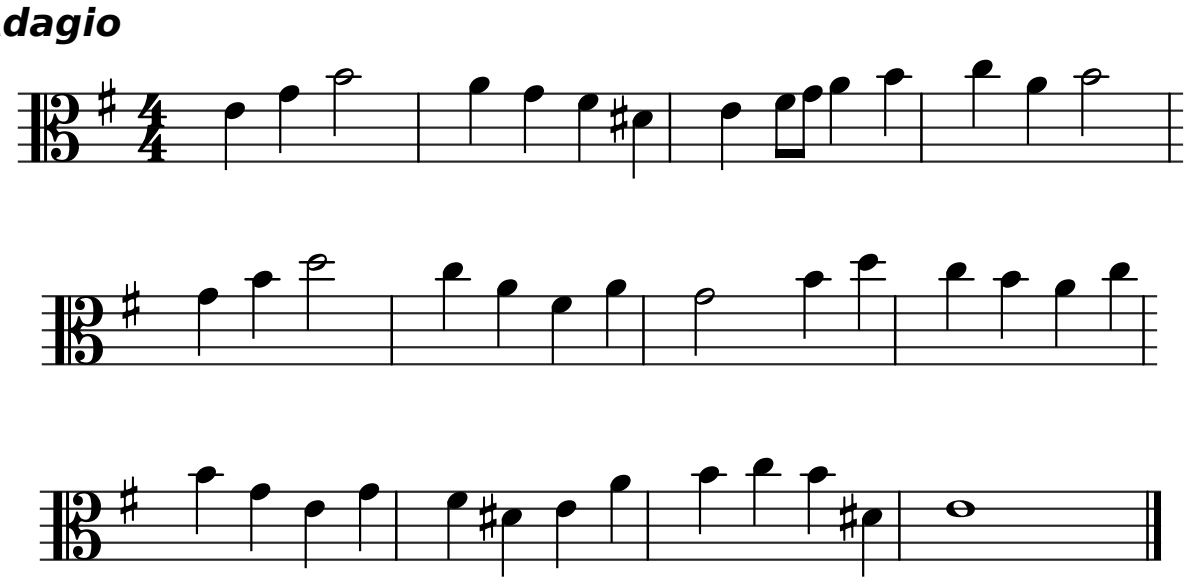


   Chords: I – VII7/V – V – I

   1. The pattern from bar 1 is kept exactly in shape and rhythm
   2. Every bar fits the harmony implied by the melody and bass
   3. Chromatic notes (secondary dominants, augmented 6ths) are spelled correctly
   4. No consecutive octaves or 5ths between the melody and the bass
   5. The cadence is clear, ending on a full tonic chord
   6. The texture suits the piano: comfortable for the hands

   Marking: start from 15. Take off 1–2 for each bar with a wrong chord or a broken pattern, and 2 for each consecutive.

3. Q3 · 20m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.



    1. Bars 1–4: the opening and a rise to B over the dominant (an imperfect cadence).
    2. Bars 5–8: D♮ instead of D♯ points to G major, the relative major, with a cadence on G in bar 7.
    3. Bars 9–12: D♯ returns; the last phrase climbs to C, then the leading note rises to E.

    Checklist:

    1. At least 12 bars, every bar the right length
    2. Clear phrases (often 4 + 4 + 4) with cadences at the ends
    3. The opening idea comes back, varied or developed (sequence, inversion, new rhythm)
    4. A modulation to a related key with the right accidental, then a clear return
    5. One high point, a good balance of steps and leaps, a strong ending on the tonic
    6. Written for the instrument: range, breathing or bowing, idiomatic figures
    7. Tempo, dynamics with changes, phrasing and articulation

4. Q4 · 3m **D: an accent: play it with extra emphasis**. It's an accent: play it with extra emphasis.
5. Q4 · 3m **D: A3**. In the alto clef middle C is on the middle line, so X is A3.
6. Q4 · 3m **A: a triad**. At X the notes are D–F♯–A: a triad.
7. Q4 · 3m **A: lively (German)**. "Lebhaft" means lively (German).
8. Q4 · 3m **A: a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II)**. X is F♯–A♯–C♯–E (V7/II): a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II).
9. Q4 · 3m **D: VII7/V**. X is G♯–B–D–F♯: VII7/V, a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of V). It is V7 of the key of V, so its leading note (G♯) rises to the root of V.
10. Q4 · 3m **A: l'istesso tempo**. l'istesso tempo means "at the same speed (the beat stays the same)".
11. Q4 · 4m **C: Fr6**. Sounding notes at X: C, E, A♯, F♯: C–E–F♯–A♯, so Fr6, a French augmented 6th.
12. Q5 · 3m **A: getting softer and slower**. calando means "getting softer and slower".
13. Q5 · 3m **C: in unison: the piccolo sounds an octave higher than written**. The piccolo sounds an octave higher than written, so its part, written an octave below the flute's, sounds at the same pitch.
14. Q5 · 3m **C: in unison: the piccolo sounds an octave higher than written**. The piccolo sounds an octave higher than written, so its part, written an octave below the flute's, sounds at the same pitch.
15. Q5 · 3m **C: E♭**. The horn in E♭ sounds a major 6th lower than written: written C sounds as E♭.

16. Q5 · 3m **D: a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of V)**. X is G–B–D–F (V7d/V): a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of V).
17. Q5 · 3m **D: plaintive, tearful**. piangevole means "plaintive, tearful".
18. Q5 · 3m **B: dying away**. smorzando (smorz.) means "dying away".
19. Q5 · 4m **A: A**. The horn in E♭ sounds a major 6th lower than written: written F♯ sounds as A.

Grade 8 practice paper 3

Time allowed: 3 hours · 100 marks · pass 66, merit 80, distinction 90

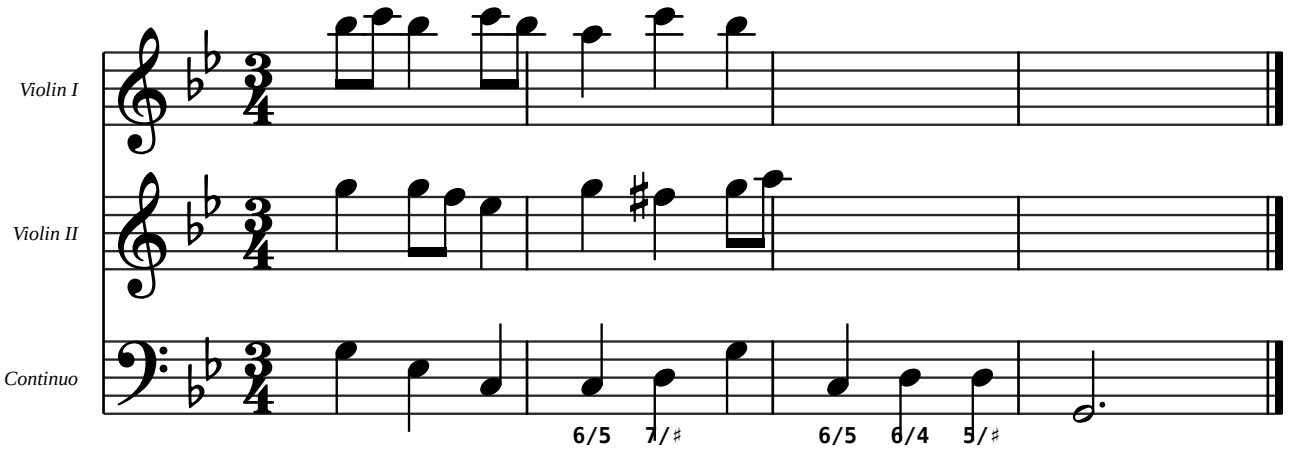
Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 100

Our own paper in the style of the ABRSM Grade 8 exam, not an ABRSM paper. Answer every question. Suggested timing: questions 1 and 2, 25 minutes each; question 3, 35 minutes; questions 4 and 5, 35 minutes each; 25 minutes to check.

Question 1: A trio sonata (15 marks)

15 marks

1. Continue the two violin parts of this trio sonata (G minor) to the end, following the figured bass. Keep the parts independent and write a cadence at the end.
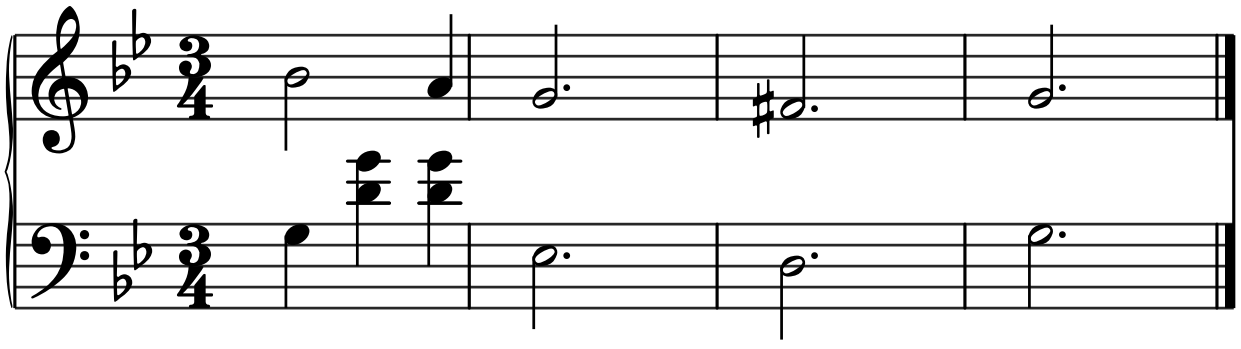


Copy onto manuscript paper, or write straight onto the staves above.

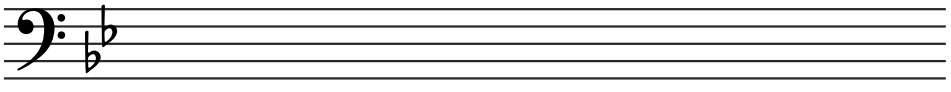
Question 2: Completing a keyboard piece (15 marks)

15 marks

2. Complete this keyboard outline (G minor). Bar 1 is complete; in the other bars the melody and bass are given. Continue the left-hand waltz bass to the end, fitting each chord.



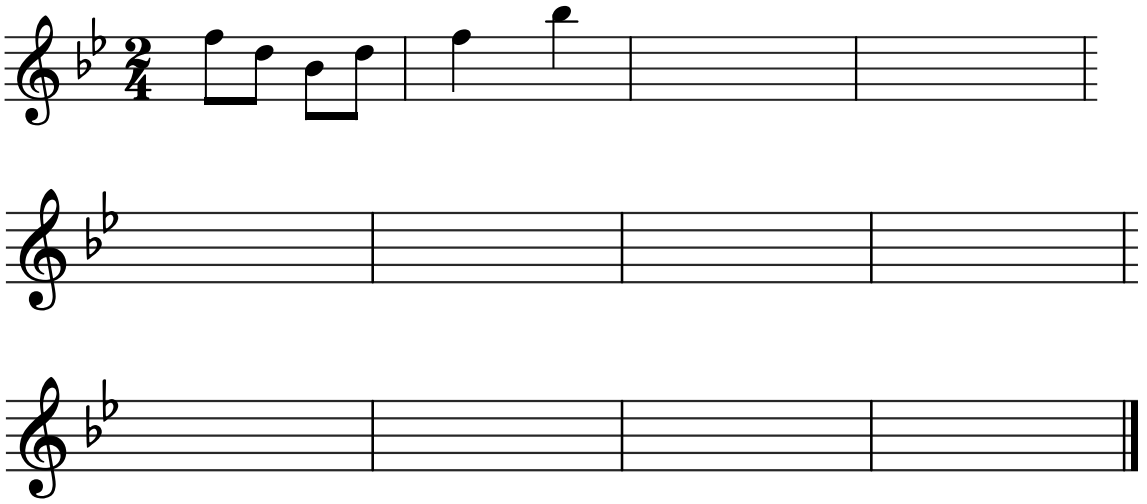
Pattern: waltz bass. Write the left hand in the empty bars.



Question 3: Composition (20 marks)

20 marks

3. Composition: continue this opening for violin (B♭ major) to make a melody of at least 12 bars. Modulate to a related key and come back, and add performance directions.
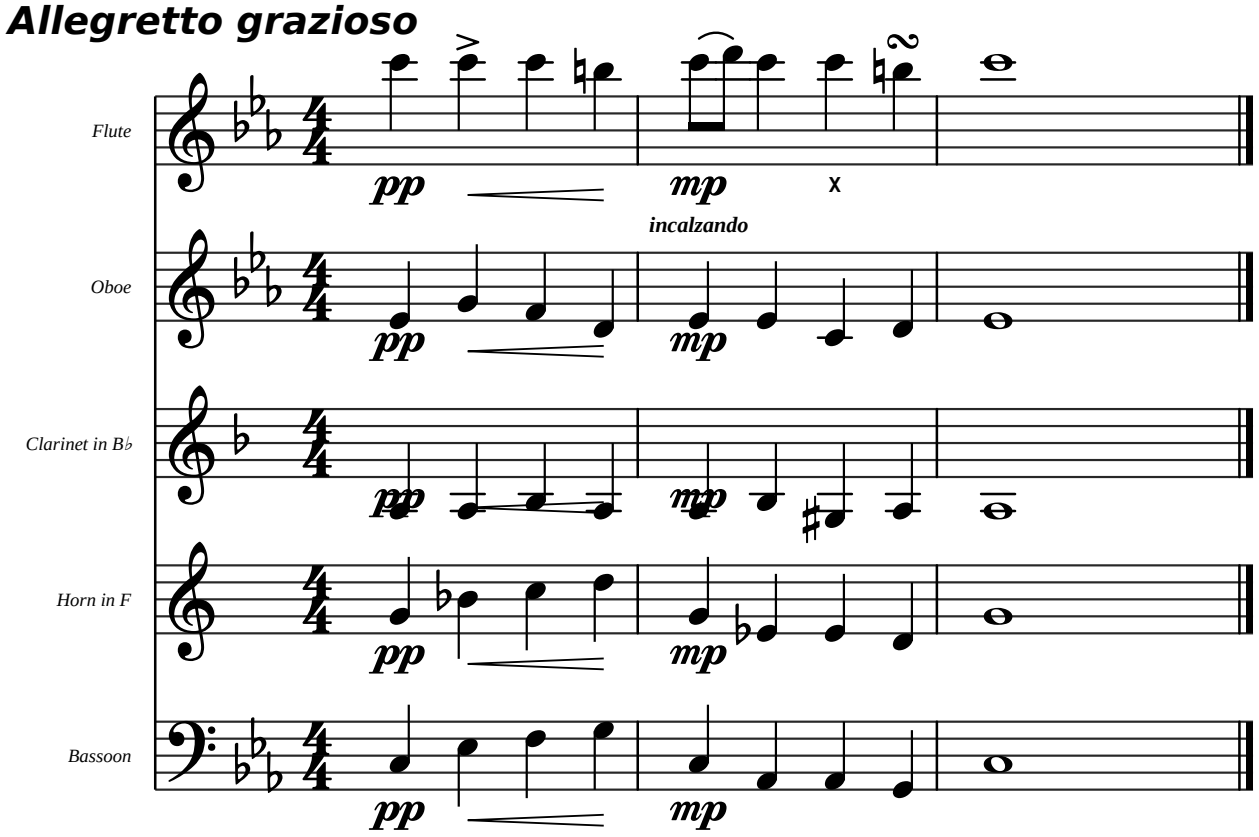


Violin range: G3 upwards (comfortably up to about E6). Add tempo, dynamics, phrasing and articulation.

Question 4: A chamber score (25 marks)

3 marks
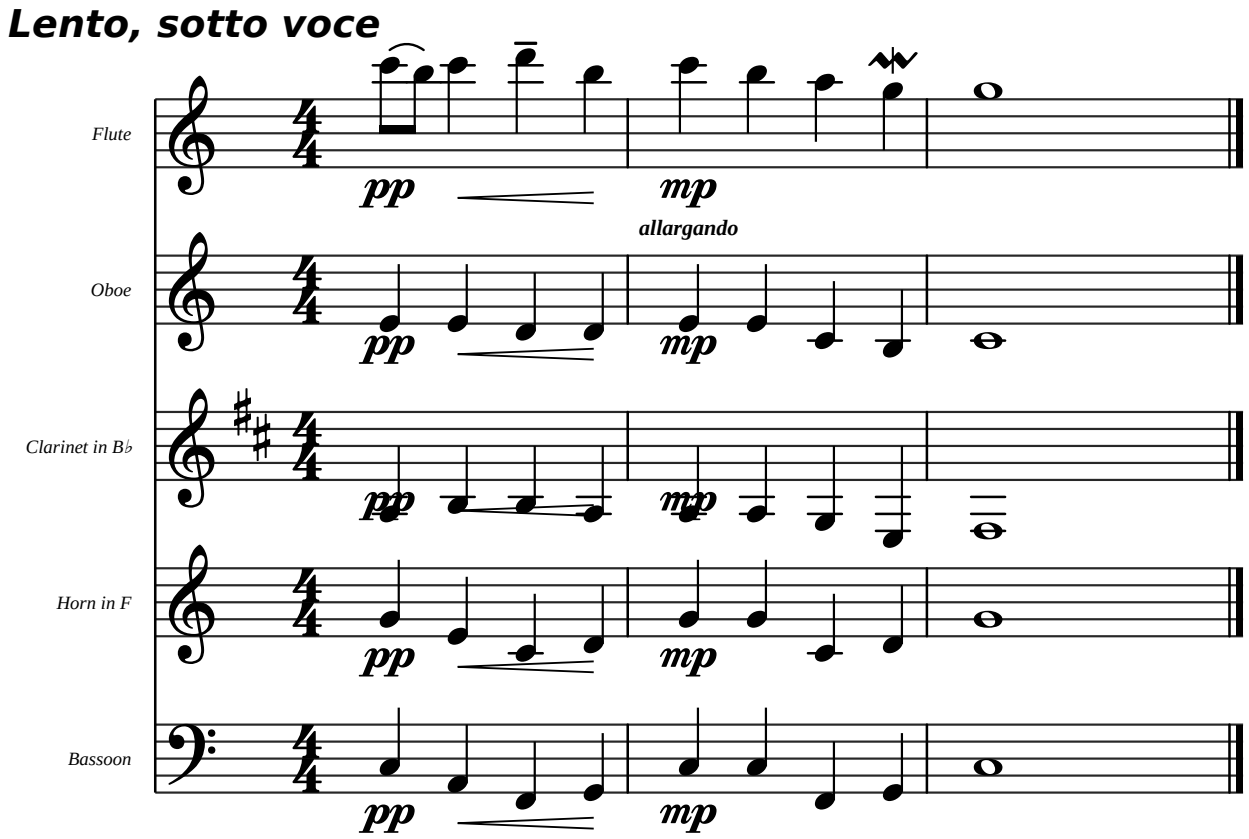
4. At X (It6 in C minor), which instrument plays the sharpened 4th?



A. Horn in F B. Oboe C. Bassoon D. Clarinet in B♭

3 marks

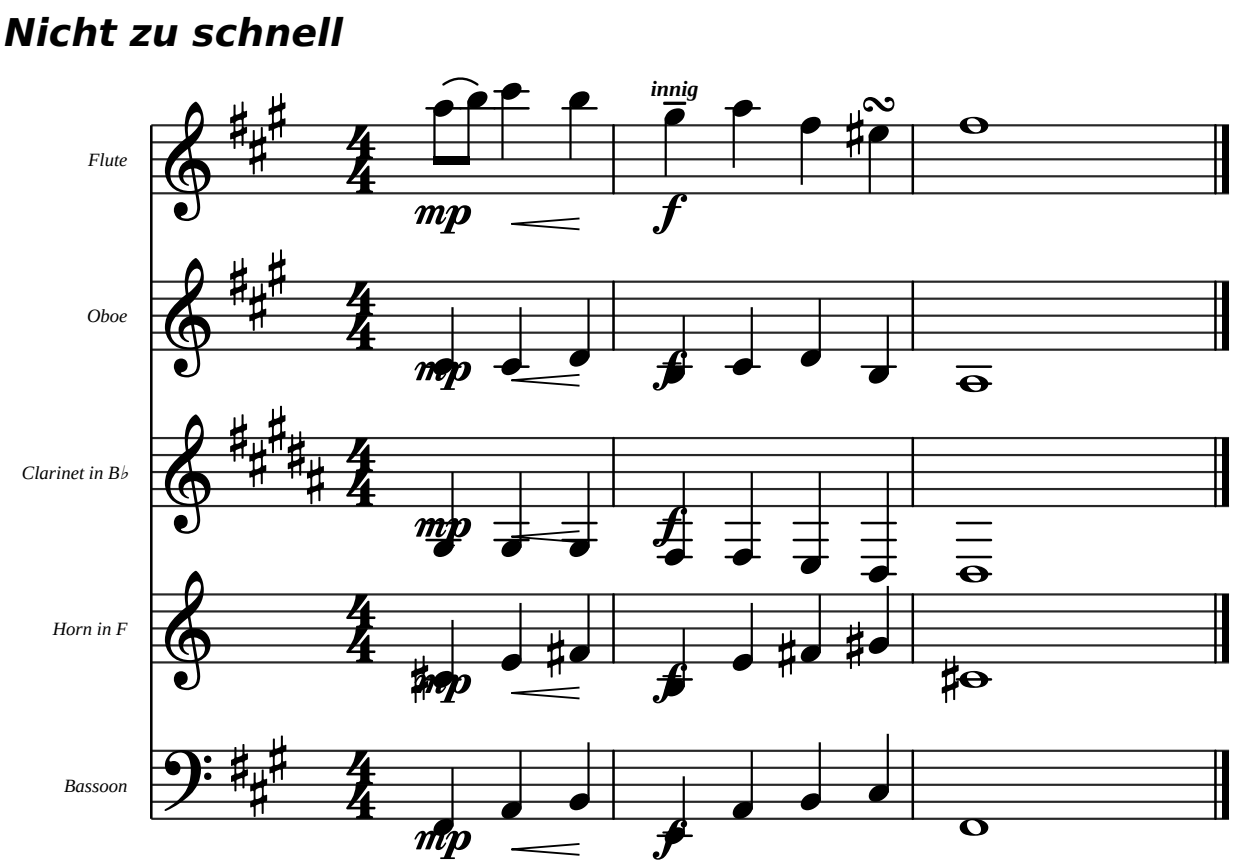
5. What does "allargando" over the oboe in bar 2 mean?



A. dying away B. broadening, getting slower and fuller C. expressively D. always smoothly

3 marks

6. Which cadence ends this extract for wind quintet? (F♯ minor)



A. plagal

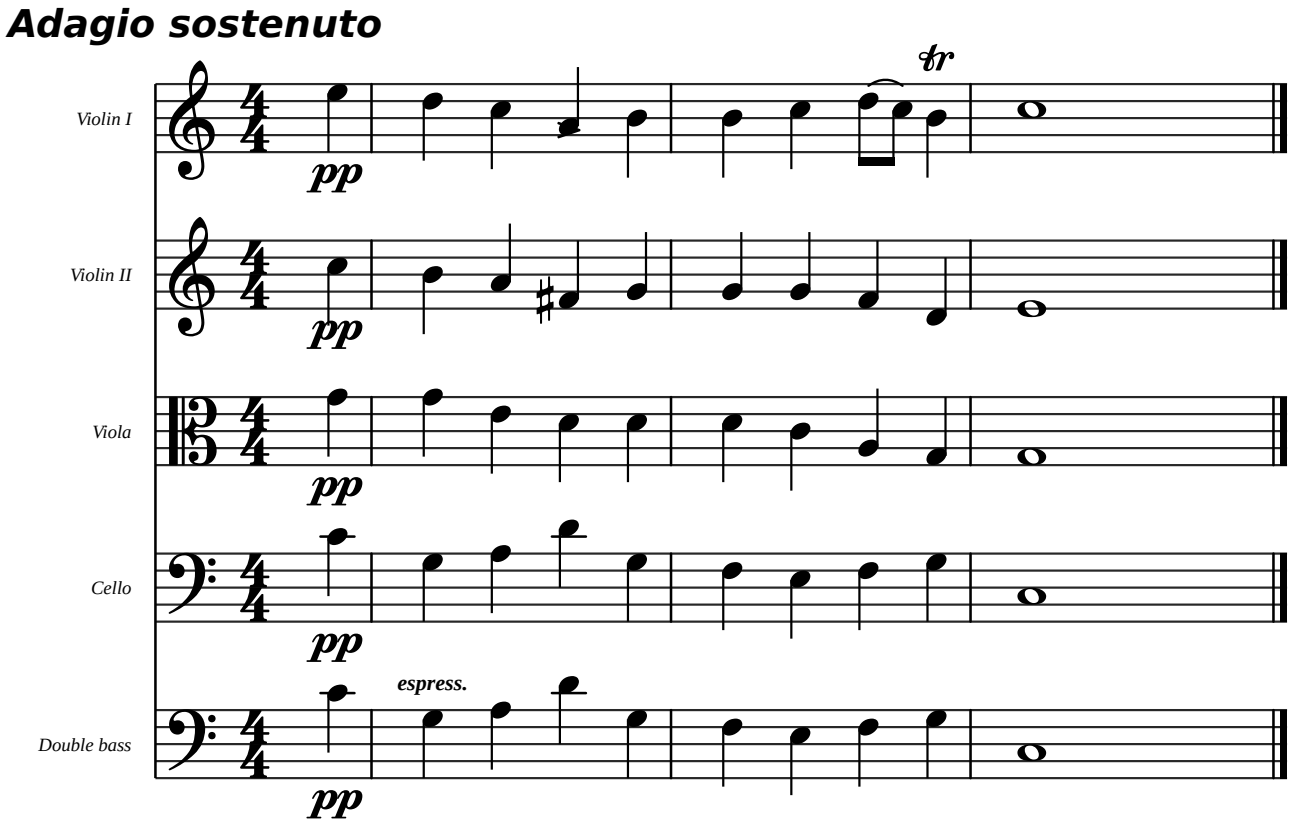
B. imperfect

C. interrupted

D. perfect

3 marks

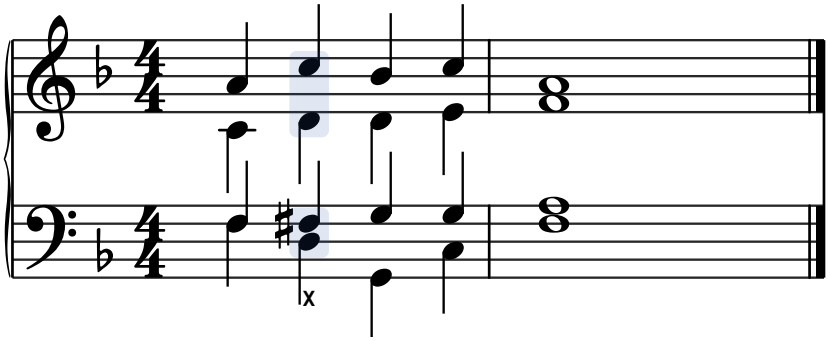
7. This piano quintet begins in C major. In which key is the cadence that ends in bar 1? (Bar 1 is the first complete bar.)



A. A minor B. G major C. D minor D. F major

3 marks

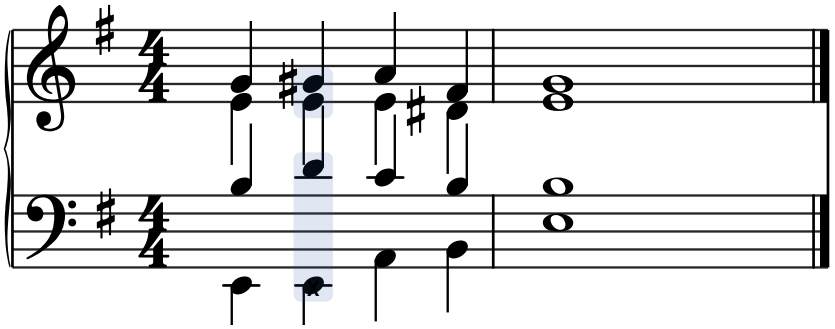
8. This passage is in F major. What kind of chord is X?



A. a German augmented 6th B. a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of IV) C. a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II) D. a French augmented 6th

3 marks

9. This passage is in E minor. Name the chord marked X.



A. VII7 B. V7/IV C. V7/V D. V7

3 marks

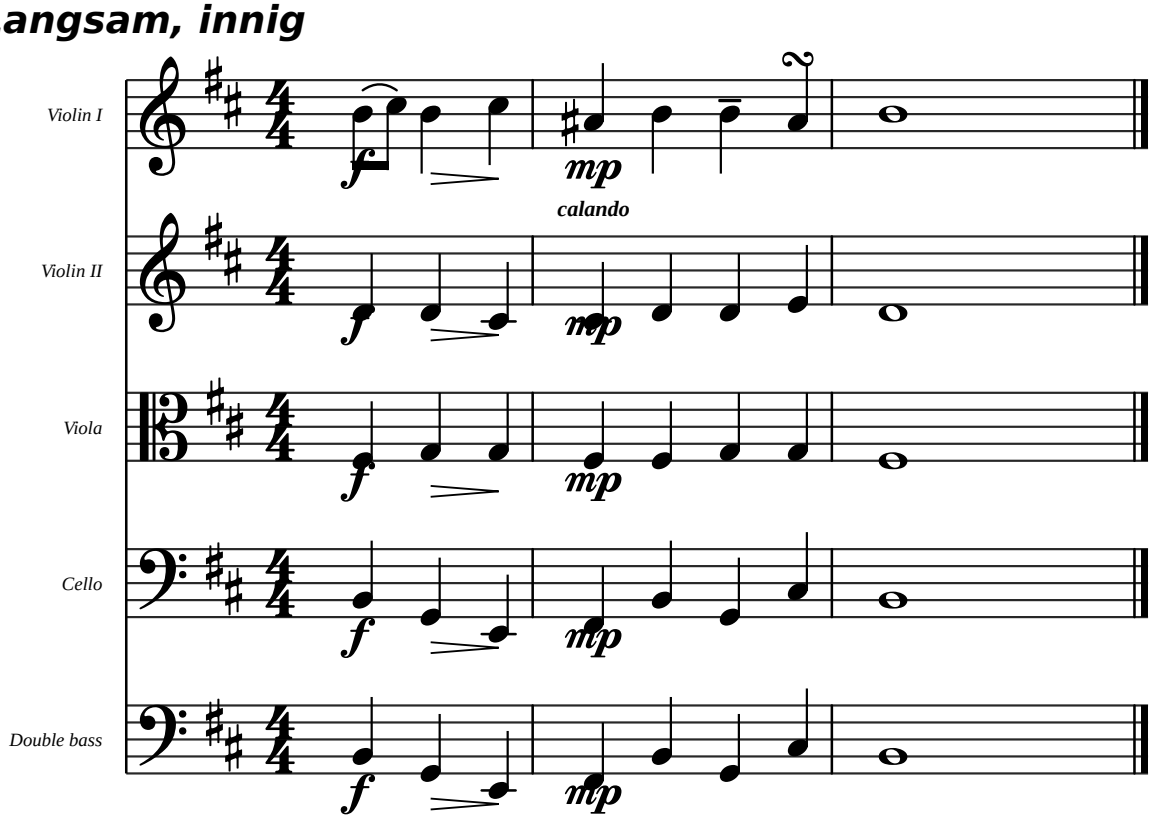
10. What does this mean?

tempo rubato

A. freely, at the performer's pleasure B. flutter-tonguing (German) C. with some freedom of time D. distant

4 marks

11. What does "calando" over the violin II in bar 1 mean? (bar 1 is the first complete bar)
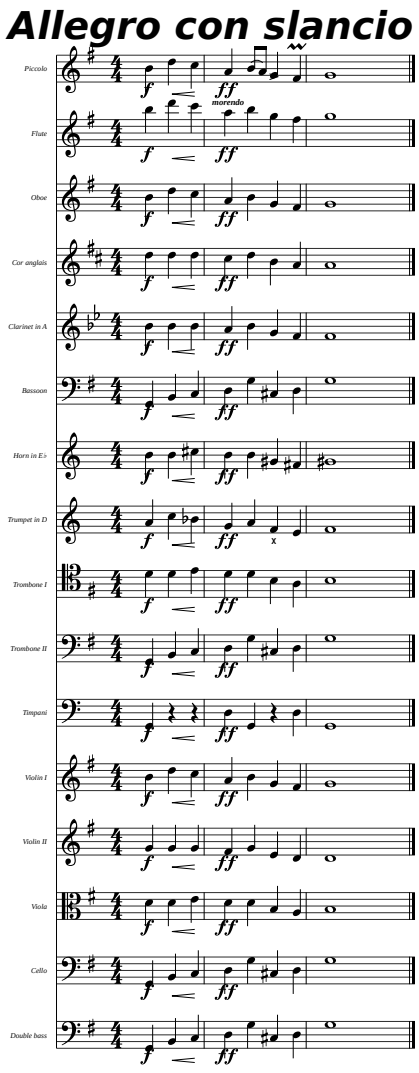


A. at half voice, restrained B. getting softer and slower C. sweetly D. bow over the fingerboard

Question 5: An orchestral score (25 marks)

3 marks
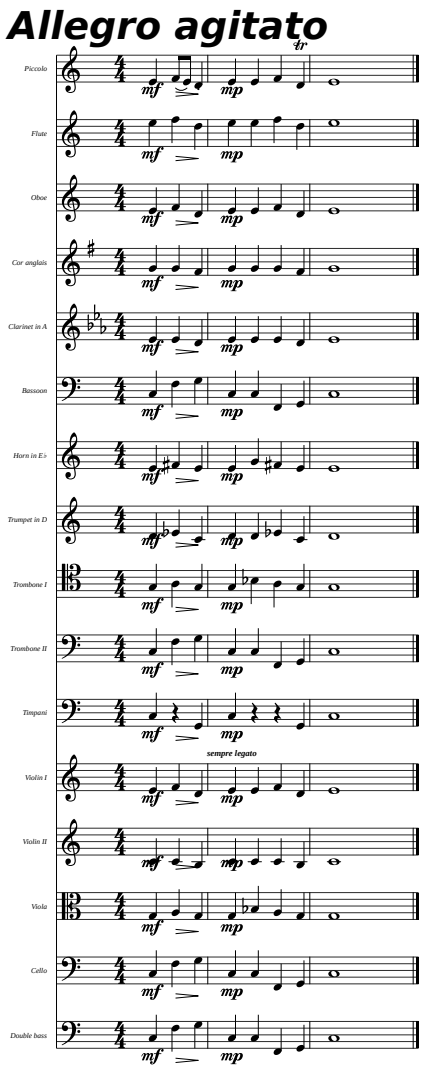
12. The trumpet in D plays the written note at X. Which note actually sounds?



A. F♯ B. F C. E D. G

3 marks

13. How loud should the music be at the start of bar 1? (bar 1 is the first complete bar)



A. very loud
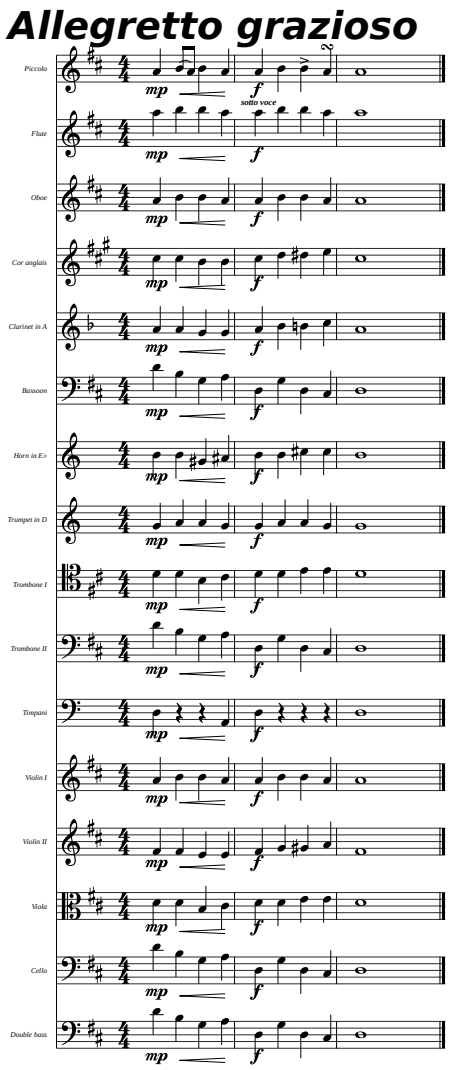
B. quiet

C. moderately loud

D. moderately quiet

3 marks

14. The timpani play only on some chords here. Which two notes are they tuned to?



A. A and E
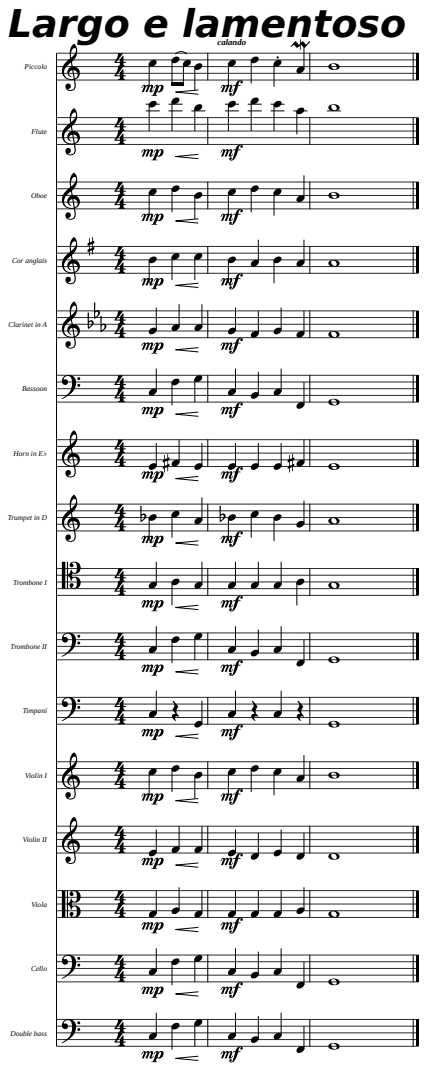
B. D and A

C. D and G

D. D and F♯

3 marks

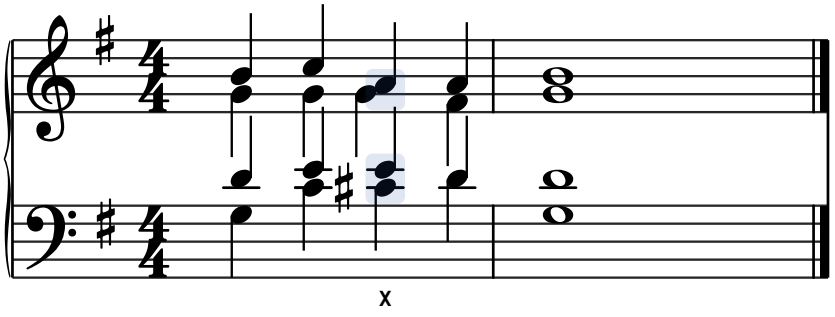
15. What does "calando" over the piccolo in bar 1 mean? (bar 1 is the first complete bar)



A. with a mute B. getting softer and slower C. heartfelt, intimate (German) D. bring the part out (French)

3 marks

16. This passage is in G major. Name the chord marked X.



A. VIIb B. V C. V7b/V D. IV

3 marks

17. What does this mean?

sur la touche

A. with some freedom of time B. hesitating, slowing (German) C. heavily D. bow over the fingerboard (French)
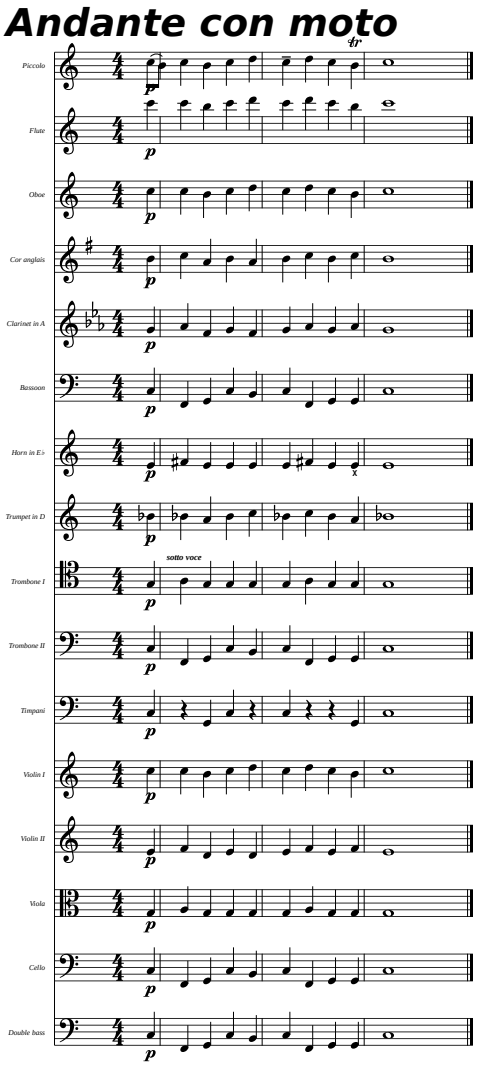
3 marks

18. Which term means "at the same speed (the beat stays the same)"?

A. misterioso B. kräftig C. l'istesso tempo D. au mouvement

4 marks

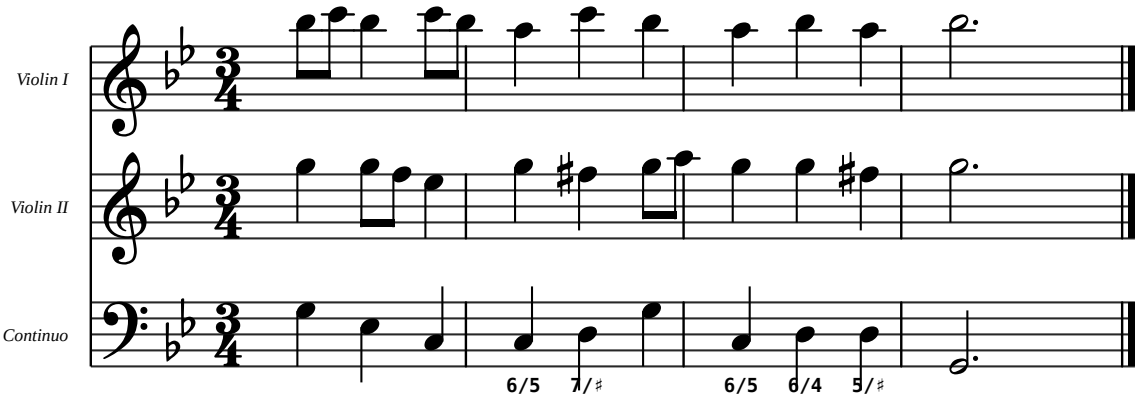
19. The horn in E♭ plays the written note at X. Which note actually sounds?



A. G B. B C. F D. A

MARKING KEY (FOR MUM)
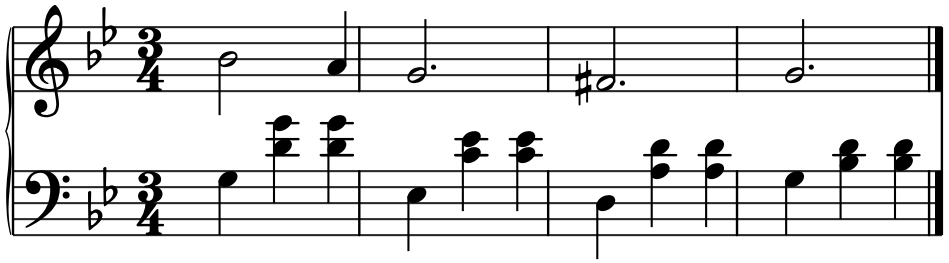
1. Q1 · 15m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.



   1. Every chord follows the figures, with the 3rd present
   2. No consecutive 5ths or octaves between any two parts (including the bass)
   3. The two violins are independent: contrary or oblique motion, some imitation or sequence
   4. Leading notes rise, 7ths fall, suspensions are prepared and resolve down
   5. The violins stay mostly within an octave of each other (they may cross)
   6. Some quaver movement for life; a clear cadence at the end

   Marking: start from 15. Take off 2 for each wrong chord, missing 3rd or consecutive; 1 for a weak part (no movement, too far apart). Other good answers earn full marks.

2. Q2 · 15m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.
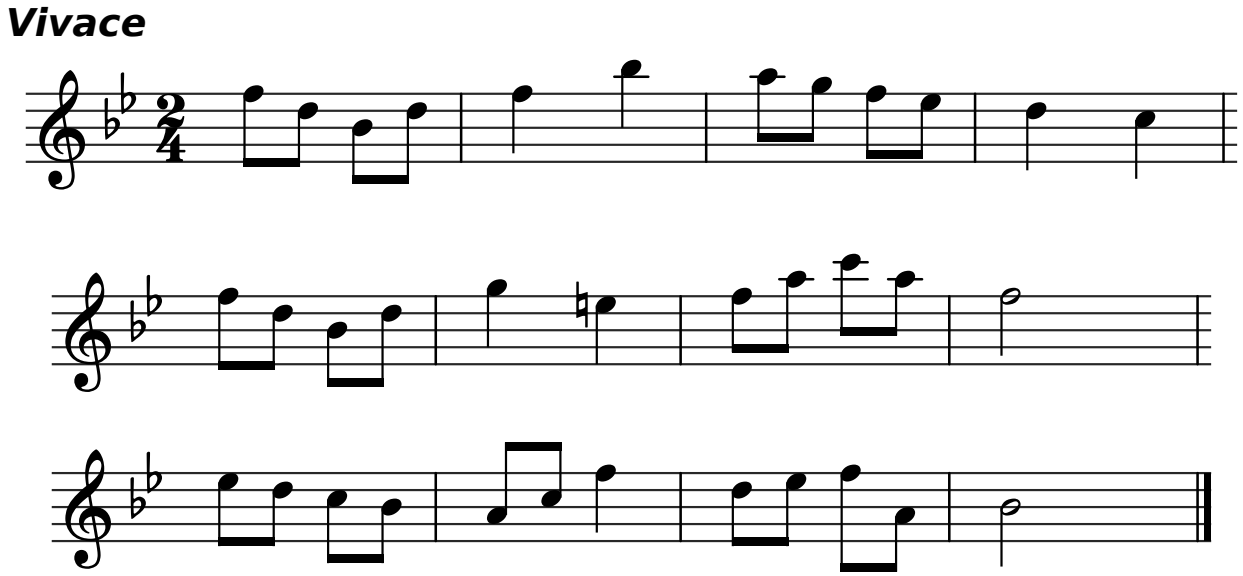


   Chords: I – IVb – V – I

   1. The pattern from bar 1 is kept exactly in shape and rhythm
   2. Every bar fits the harmony implied by the melody and bass
   3. Chromatic notes (secondary dominants, augmented 6ths) are spelled correctly
   4. No consecutive octaves or 5ths between the melody and the bass
   5. The cadence is clear, ending on a full tonic chord
   6. The texture suits the piano: comfortable for the hands

   Marking: start from 15. Take off 1–2 for each bar with a wrong chord or a broken pattern, and 2 for each consecutive.

3. Q3 · 20m **Mark with the checklist; one model answer below**.



   1. Bars 1–4: the lively opening and a scale falling to C (an imperfect cadence).
   2. Bars 5–8: E♮ takes the music to F major, the dominant, cadencing on F in bar 8.
   3. Bars 9–12: E♭ returns; the last phrase ends with A, the leading note, rising to B♭.

   Checklist:

   1. At least 12 bars, every bar the right length
   2. Clear phrases (often 4 + 4 + 4) with cadences at the ends
   3. The opening idea comes back, varied or developed (sequence, inversion, new rhythm)
   4. A modulation to a related key with the right accidental, then a clear return
   5. One high point, a good balance of steps and leaps, a strong ending on the tonic
   6. Written for the instrument: range, breathing or bowing, idiomatic figures
   7. Tempo, dynamics with changes, phrasing and articulation
4. Q4 · 3m **D: Clarinet in B♭**. Clarinet in B♭ has F♯: the sharpened 4th (it rises a semitone to the dominant).
5. Q4 · 3m **B: broadening, getting slower and fuller**. allargando means "broadening, getting slower and fuller".
6. Q4 · 3m **D: perfect**. The last two chords are V7–I: a perfect cadence.
7. Q4 · 3m **B: G major**. The music modulates to G major, the dominant: the new sharp (F♯) is its leading note, and the cadence is V–I in G major.
8. Q4 · 3m **C: a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II)**. X is D–F♯–A–C (V7/II): a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of II).
9. Q4 · 3m **B: V7/IV**. X is E–G♯–B–D: V7/IV, a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of IV). It is V7 of the key of IV, so its leading note (G♯) rises to the root of IV.
10. Q4 · 3m **C: with some freedom of time**. tempo rubato means "with some freedom of time".
11. Q4 · 4m **B: getting softer and slower**. calando means "getting softer and slower".
12. Q5 · 3m **D: G**. The trumpet in D sounds a major 2nd higher than written: written F sounds as G.
13. Q5 · 3m **D: moderately quiet**. mp means moderately quiet; the diminuendo hairpin before it leads there.
14. Q5 · 3m **B: D and A**. Classical timpani are tuned to the tonic and dominant: D and A in D major. They join in on I and V.
15. Q5 · 3m **B: getting softer and slower**. calando means "getting softer and slower".

16. Q5 · 3m **C: V7b/V**. X is A–C♯–E–G: V7b/V, a secondary dominant (dominant 7th of V). It is V7 of the key of V, so its leading note (C♯) rises to the root of V.
17. Q5 · 3m **D: bow over the fingerboard (French)**. sur la touche means "bow over the fingerboard (French)".
18. Q5 · 3m **C: l'istesso tempo**. l'istesso tempo means "at the same speed (the beat stays the same)".
19. Q5 · 4m **A: G**. The horn in E♭ sounds a major 6th lower than written: written E sounds as G.